

Archy: A Natural History of Power Over Others

The full inquiry — mechanisms, quantities, roles, the excluded, and the honest doubts — from the first foragers to the present

Introduction to the combined volume

This is a single inquiry into one question: how did the power of some human beings to command, extract from, and dispose of others come into the world, harden into structure, reinvent itself across roughly three hundred thousand years — and was it ever inevitable? The word for that power, stripped of its prefixes, is *archy* (from the Greek *arkhē*, "rule" and also "beginning"), the bare relation hidden inside monarchy, oligarchy, patriarchy, and hierarchy alike.

The inquiry is built in five parts, each approaching the same eight eras from a different angle, and each correcting a distortion the others risk on their own.

Part I — A Natural History of Archy is the spine. It traces the *mechanisms*: the door-opening devices — surplus and storage, the loss of exit, the defeat of leveling, control of subsistence, inheritance, debt, the ledger, sacralization, dispersed responsibility, and the masking of coercion as free exchange — by which power over others is generated and, occasionally, dismantled. It establishes the framing the whole work depends on: that sustained equality, not hierarchy, was the human baseline for most of our existence, and that archy is therefore the deviation to be explained.

Part II — Power, Wealth, and Inequality Across the Eras makes the spine *quantitative*. It asks, era by era, how big the groups were, how they were structured, what people contributed and kept and accumulated, who pushed back, and on what grounds rulers claimed to rule — and it carries the numbers, marked by their certainty, including the master table that runs from door-opening mechanisms on the left to practiced archy on the right.

Part III — The Cast and the Machine supplies *fixed categories* for comparison. It names six functional roles — Owners, Organizers, Enforcers, Legitimizers, Producers, Dependents — that recur in every era, tracks how they bundle at the apex and split apart, and follows the administrative state's rise from nothing to maximal reach, asking at each step how private power taps into the machine.

Part IV — The Excluded, the Cracks, and the Counter-Cases cuts *across* the eras to correct three distortions. It disaggregates "the many" into the specific groups every hierarchy sorted to the bottom — by gender, race, age, disability, and sexuality — and traces their subordination

through the whole institutional stack (household, religion, school, state, profession, corporation, society). It recovers the quiet resistance — flight, sabotage, the hidden transcript — that carried the leveling impulse through eras when revolt meant death. It puts the stateless and non-Western societies that refused kings at the center. And it adds the material drivers — the plow, the horse, the printing press, the engine — beneath the social story.

Part V — The Case Against This Analysis turns the strongest objections against the whole project: that hierarchy is natural rather than a deviation, that it is efficient and funded civilization, that inequality is the price of innovation, that the egalitarian past is romanticized, and — most gravely, following Walter Scheidel — that inequality has only ever fallen through catastrophe, never through peaceful reform. It concedes that the hopeful reading may be wrong, and strips the thesis down to the more modest claim the evidence actually supports.

A note on reading order. Part I is self-contained and can be read alone. Parts II and III deepen it and assume its framing. Part IV complicates it and is, for many readers, the heart of the work. Part V disciplines the whole. The honest conclusion the five parts converge on is not that we are destined for equality, nor doomed to hierarchy, but that archy is *conditional* — a function of mechanisms, roles, material conditions, and choices that have been arranged many different ways, and that remains, therefore, contestable.

A note on certainty. Throughout, claims are marked where they rest on real measurement [measured], scholarly reconstruction [estimated], analogy or indirect evidence [inferred], or active dispute [contested]. Certainty degrades as we go back in time; the deep past is reconstruction, the present is measurement, and the text tries never to disguise which is which.

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- **Part V — The Case Against This Analysis** (*the honest objections*)

The eight eras referenced throughout are: (1) Forager egalitarianism, to c. 12,000 BCE; (2) The Neolithic threshold, c. 12,000–4,000 BCE; (3) The first states and god-kings, c. 4,000–800 BCE; (4) Classical empires and slavery, c. 800 BCE–500 CE; (5) Feudal and tributary orders, c. 500–1450; (6) Mercantilism, colonialism, and the Atlantic system, c. 1450–1800; (7) Industrial capitalism, c. 1800–1970; (8) The present, c. 1970–now.

Part I — A Natural History of Archy

The mechanisms. This part is the spine of the whole work: how the power of one human over another is generated and dismantled, era by era, and whether it was ever inevitable.

Preface: What "archy" is, and why the baseline matters

The word *archy* — from the Greek *arkhē*, meaning both "beginning" and "rule" — names the thing all the familiar compounds share: monarchy, oligarchy, patriarchy, hierarchy. Strip the prefixes and what remains is the bare relation: the institutionalized power of some humans to command, extract from, or dispose of others. This document traces how that relation came into the world, hardened into structure, and reinvented itself across roughly 300,000 years of human social life.

The single most important analytical decision in a project like this is where you put the zero point. If you assume that hierarchy is the natural human condition — that we are status-seeking primates who build dominance ladders the moment we're left alone — then the interesting question becomes why equality ever appears, and equality looks like the fragile, artificial achievement. If instead you take sustained political equality as something our species not only *can* do but did, for the overwhelming majority of its existence, then **archy becomes the deviation that needs explaining**, and the whole inquiry inverts.

The evidence supports the second framing, with an important qualification. Foragers were not equal because they lacked the capacity for domination — they were equal because they *worked at it*, deploying active mechanisms to stop would-be dominators. This matters enormously for everything that follows. It means archy is not the absence of a restraint that civilization later supplied; it is the *failure or dismantling* of restraints that egalitarian societies had already invented. Every later chapter is, in part, the story of how those restraints were overwhelmed, bought off, sacralized away, or simply outscaled.

A second framing decision concerns the word "inevitable." A tempting story runs: agriculture → surplus → storage → some people control the storage → inequality → the state, each arrow automatic. Recent archaeology and anthropology have made this chain look far less like a law of nature and far more like a series of contingent, reversible, often-resisted transitions. The honest position is neither "inequality was always coming" nor "inequality was a single catastrophic wrong turn," but something harder: humans have repeatedly built hierarchy *and* repeatedly dismantled it, and the ratchet only locked in particular places under particular conditions. Where this document can show the ratchet *not* locking — societies that had cities

without kings, surplus without aristocracy, scale without servitude — those cases are doing the heaviest analytical lifting, because they break the spell of inevitability.

A note on method. This synthesizes archaeology, anthropology, history, and economics, and these fields disagree. Where there's a live scholarly fight — and there are several — the text flags it rather than papering over it. The aim is not a single tidy thesis but a map of the mechanisms: the recurring devices by which power over others is generated, stored, transmitted, legitimated, and resisted.

Era 1 — Forager egalitarianism

Deep prehistory – c. 12,000 BCE: the baseline, and how it was actively maintained

For something like 95% of the time anatomically modern humans have existed, people lived in small, mobile groups without rulers, without inherited rank, without the institutional means for one person to compel another. To call this "equality" can mislead a modern ear — it does not mean everyone was the same, or that there were no differences in skill, influence, or esteem. It means something more specific and more interesting: there was no stable, transmissible, *coercive* power of one person over another. Influence existed; command did not.

What the equality actually consisted of

Three things were genuinely flat in mobile forager life, and it's worth separating them because later eras pry them apart one by one.

The first is **material**. With frequent movement, accumulation is a burden, not an asset — you carry what you own. There is little durable wealth to hoard and nothing like land tenure when the band ranges over a territory it does not individually parcel. The second is **political**: decisions were reached by discussion, persuasion, and consensus, and individuals retained the option to simply leave — to walk to another band — which is the most powerful check on a bully that exists. The third is **informational and economic**: in a sharing economy organized around the daily distribution of hunted and gathered food, no one controls the others' subsistence. You cannot starve someone into obedience when everyone has independent access to the food supply and a strong norm compels its sharing.

The key insight: equality was performed, not passive

Here is the finding that overturns the "natural ladder" intuition. Forager equality was not the placid default of creatures too simple to dominate. It was a *vigilant political achievement*, maintained by what the anthropologist Christopher Boehm called **reverse dominance hierarchy**: the rank and file, the would-be subordinates, collectively dominate anyone who tries to rise above them. The many keep the one down. This is the mirror image of the ape troop, and it is everywhere in the ethnographic record of mobile foragers.

The toolkit of leveling mechanisms is remarkably consistent across unrelated societies on different continents, which suggests it answers a recurring problem rather than reflecting a single culture:

- **Mockery and ridicule.** The arrogant or domineering are teased relentlessly. Humor is a precision instrument for deflating status without open conflict.
- **Insulting the meat.** Among the Ju/'hoansi (!Kung) of the Kalahari, a hunter who brings in a large kill is mocked for bringing something so scrawny and worthless. The hunter is *expected* to disparage his own success. The point, as one Ju/'hoan man famously explained to the anthropologist Richard Lee, is explicit: when a young man kills much meat he comes to think of himself as a chief or a big man, and he thinks of the rest as his inferiors — so "we refuse one who boasts," and we cool his heart and make him gentle by calling his meat worthless. The leveling is *theorized* by its practitioners. They know exactly what they are preventing.
- **Demand sharing.** The norm that anyone may ask for a portion, and refusal is a grave offense, means surplus cannot pool in one set of hands.
- **Disengagement and mobility.** Fission — splitting off — is always available, so no one is trapped under a domineering personality.
- **The ultimate sanctions.** Where ridicule and ostracism fail against a genuinely dangerous, violent, or domineering individual, the ethnographic record documents the group resorting to expulsion and, in extremis, sanctioned execution of the upstart, often carried out by a close kinsman to forestall a feud.

Inequality of *esteem* persisted — good hunters, wise elders, gifted storytellers, skilled mediators were admired and listened to. But esteem was not convertible into command, and crucially it was not heritable. A great hunter's son inherited no office. The conversion of fleeting prestige into durable, transmissible power is precisely the thing these societies blocked, and precisely the thing later societies would learn to enable.

Complication: foragers were not all the same

The picture above describes *mobile, immediate-return* foragers — those who consume what they get rather than storing it. But the foraging world was far more varied, and the variation is the seed of everything later. **Delayed-return foragers** — who invest in fixed facilities like fish weirs, smokehouses, and stored caches — show, in some cases, marked hierarchy. The most famous are the Indigenous peoples of the Pacific Northwest Coast (Kwakwaka'wakw, Tlingit, Haida and others): sedentary or semi-sedentary, living off astonishingly rich salmon runs, with hereditary nobility, commoners, and chattel slavery — without any agriculture at all. Their wealth was displayed and redistributed through the *potlatch*, a competitive feast at which a chief gave away or destroyed enormous quantities of goods to assert rank.

This is a hinge fact. It shows that the trigger for hierarchy is **not farming as such** but a cluster — storable concentrated resources, reduced mobility, defensible wealth — that farming would

later supply reliably but that nature occasionally supplied on its own. It also shows that mobility and the right to leave are doing much of the egalitarian work: take them away, and rank can grow even among hunter-gatherers.

The deep-history complication: maybe it wasn't monotonous at all

The traditional account treats the Palaeolithic as one long uniform plateau of small egalitarian bands. A newer body of work, associated with the archaeologist David Wengrow and the late anthropologist David Graeber, argues that the deep past was politically *experimental* and *seasonal*. The richly furnished Upper Palaeolithic burials of Sungir (in Russia, c. 34,000 years ago) — children laid out with tens of thousands of painstakingly drilled mammoth-ivory beads — and the monumental hunter-gatherer sanctuary at Göbekli Tepe in Anatolia (c. 9500 BCE, pre-agricultural) suggest concentrations of labor, ritual authority, or status that don't fit a flat band model. Their reading: some Ice Age societies may have *oscillated*, assembling into large hierarchical formations for part of the year (a ceremonial season, a herd hunt) and dispersing into small egalitarian groups for the rest — consciously moving between political modes. On this view the human political repertoire was capacious and self-aware from very early, and permanent hierarchy is less a discovery than a *getting stuck* in one season of a cycle humans had long known how to exit.

This is contested — the lavish burials might mark unusual individuals rather than institutions, and seasonal readings strain some of the evidence — but even the cautious version dislodges the comfortable assumption that our ancestors simply didn't know how to be unequal until farming taught them. They knew. They mostly chose otherwise, and built tools to enforce the choice.

What this baseline establishes

Three conclusions carry forward and structure everything below.

First, **the human capacity for both domination and its suppression is ancient and co-present**. We are not by nature levelers or by nature climbers; we are both, and which one prevails is a matter of institutions and conditions, not biology.

First among the conditions: **archy requires that the leveling mechanisms be defeated**. Mockery, sharing, mobility, the right to leave — each of these will be neutralized, one at a time, in the chapters ahead. Watch for the moment in each era when leaving stops being an option, because that is usually the moment archy locks.

And third, **the trigger is not any single technology but a configuration** — concentrated, storable, defensible resources plus reduced exit. The Neolithic is about to supply that configuration on a vast scale and make it permanent. Whether it *had* to produce kings is the question of the next part.

Era 2 — The Neolithic threshold

c. 12,000 – 4,000 BCE: settlement, storage, surplus, and the contested birth of inequality

This is the pivot of the whole story, and the place where the word "inevitable" must either earn its keep or be retired. The old account is clean and powerful, which is why it became the default. It runs like this: people began farming; farming produced more food than was immediately needed; surplus had to be stored; stored surplus was concentrated and seizable in a way that a daily catch of game never was; whoever controlled the stores controlled the people who needed them; control hardened into office, office into rank, rank into the state. Sedentism also ended the great equalizer of mobility — you cannot vote with your feet when your fields, your granary, and your ancestors' graves are *here*. The leveling mechanisms of Era 1 quietly died: you cannot fission away from a field you have cleared over a decade, and demand-sharing cannot survive a harvest that one household grew and another did not.

Every link in that chain is real. The problem is that the chain did not, in fact, snap shut everywhere it could have, and the exceptions are now too numerous and too well-documented to treat as noise.

What actually happened to time and resistance

The Neolithic was not an event but a process drawn out over millennia, and it did not begin with farming. The earliest monumental site we know, **Göbekli Tepe**, was built by hunter-gatherers around 9500 BCE — massive carved stone pillars arranged by people who had not yet domesticated their staple crops. Whatever authority coordinated that labor, it preceded the granary. Conversely, many early farming communities show a stubborn *commitment to equality* long after they had the surplus that supposedly makes hierarchy automatic.

The most spectacular case is **Çatalhöyük** in central Anatolia (c. 7100–5700 BCE), a town of several thousand people packed into nearly identical mudbrick houses entered through the roof. For something like a thousand years — far longer than most later dynasties last — this large, dense, fully agricultural community shows almost no architectural evidence of rank: no palace, no elite quarter, no rich-versus-poor housing, no monumental tombs. Houses are strikingly uniform in size and contents. People were doing the supposedly impossible: living packed together, farming, storing food, *and* refusing to let hierarchy crystallize, apparently through a powerful ideology of household equivalence and ancestral continuity (the dead were buried beneath the floors of the homes). Çatalhöyük is the single most important piece of evidence against strong inevitability, because it removes every excuse — they had the surplus, the density, and the sedentism, and still the ratchet did not lock for a millennium.

The slow, reversible, resisted character of the transition

Three features of the new archaeology dismantle the automatic-chain model.

The transition was **slow and partial**. People practiced "play farming" — cultivating some plants casually for centuries or millennia without committing to full agricultural dependence, keeping a foot in the foraging world. The notion of a sudden "Agricultural Revolution" that flipped a switch is an artifact of looking at the deep past through a telescope that compresses three thousand years into a sentence.

The transition was **reversible**. Societies took up farming and then *abandoned* it; took up hierarchy and then *dismantled* it. Some Neolithic communities show a phase of emergent inequality followed by a deliberate return to flatter arrangements — the ratchet running backwards. This is fatal to any model in which inequality, once it appears, can only grow.

And the transition was **resisted**. The leveling instinct of Era 1 did not vanish when people settled down; it adapted, and you can read the struggle in the ground. Across Neolithic Europe the great communal **megalithic tombs** — long barrows, passage graves, the dolmens — pool many bodies together anonymously, an architecture that asserts the collective over any individual, the community of ancestors over any single lineage's claim to greatness. This is the leveling ethos rendered in stone, a deliberate refusal of the individuating monument. The contrast with what comes next — the single richly furnished royal grave shouting one person's supremacy — measures exactly how far archy had to travel and how hard it was pushed back.

The mechanisms that *did* generate inequality, where it took

When inequality did take root, it ran through identifiable channels, and naming them precisely matters because the same channels recur for the next ten thousand years.

Storage and the calendar of scarcity. A granary is a battery of stored power. Whoever controls access to it controls the hungry gap between harvests — the lean season when last year's grain is the only thing between a family and starvation. This is the first time in human history that one person can systematically command another by controlling the food supply, the exact lever that the forager sharing economy had been engineered to deny anyone.

The house, the heir, and inheritance. Sedentism creates the durable household as an economic unit, and the durable household creates the *heritable estate* — fields cleared, animals bred, granaries built, all of it now passing from parents to children. Inheritance is the device that converts a one-generation advantage into a dynasty. The forager prohibition on heritable rank is overwhelmed not by force but by the simple accumulation of transmissible things.

Prestige goods and the debt of the feast. Long-distance trade in rare valuables — obsidian, fine stone, later copper and gold — let aspiring leaders accumulate wealth that was portable, durable, and impressive. The competitive feast (the Neolithic ancestor of the potlatch) let them convert that wealth into followers: a lavish feast puts the guests in a debt of obligation they can only discharge through loyalty and labor. This is the "aggrandizer" or "big man" pathway theorized by the archaeologist Brian Hayden — ambitious individuals exploiting surplus to build

webs of obligation, turning generosity itself into a tool of domination. The forager who insulted the meat to deflate the booster was defending against *exactly* this, and in the Neolithic, with stored surplus to draw on, the booster finally had the resources to win.

Animals, herds, and movable wealth. Domesticated livestock are wealth that breeds, that can be counted, raided, given as bridewealth, and accumulated without limit. In much of the world the herd, not the field, was the first great engine of inequality — and pastoralism produced its own steep hierarchies and its own warrior aristocracies.

The verdict on inevitability

The honest synthesis is this. The Neolithic supplied the *necessary conditions* for durable archy — storable surplus, reduced mobility, heritable estates, the death of demand-sharing — and once those conditions were widespread, hierarchy became *available* in a way it had never been before. But "available" is not "inevitable." Çatalhöyük had every necessary condition and stayed flat for a thousand years. Other communities built inequality and then chose to tear it down. The conditions loaded the dice; they did not throw them.

What the Neolithic really did was raise the *stakes* and weaken the *defenses*. The leveling mechanisms still operated, but they were fighting on worse terrain: against heritable wealth, against the granary's quiet coercion, against the feast's web of debt, and without the trump card of easy exit. Sometimes they won, for centuries. But the terrain now favored the aggrandizer, and over the long run, in the richest and most crowded river valleys, the defenses would be not merely defeated but *inverted* — turned into their opposite, so that the very ideology of community and sharing would be captured and redeployed to justify a king who fed his people from a granary he owned. That inversion is the work of the next part.

Era 3 — The first states and the god-kings

c. 4,000 – 800 BCE: writing, temples, taxation, and the sacralization of command

Somewhere in the fourth millennium BCE, in southern Mesopotamia and then the Nile valley, the available hierarchy of the late Neolithic became something qualitatively new: the **state**. Not merely a rich man with followers, but a standing apparatus — offices that outlived their holders, a class that did not farm, a machinery for extracting and recording the labor of everyone else. This is the threshold at which archy stops being a recurring social tendency and becomes an *institution* with the power to reproduce itself across generations regardless of the personalities involved. Understanding how it locked in here — and why it did *not* lock in everywhere comparable — is the core of this part.

Four technologies of permanent power

The early states ran on a small set of interlocking inventions, each of which solved a problem that had previously kept hierarchy fragile.

Writing, born as accountancy. It is one of the most clarifying facts in all of history that writing was not invented to record poetry, law, or prayer. It was invented to keep accounts. The earliest texts from Uruk, around 3300 BCE, are administrative: lists of grain, livestock, laborers, and rations, impressed into clay by temple bureaucrats. Before writing, memory limited how much could be owed, owned, and tracked; a debt could be forgotten, a tribute disputed. Writing made obligation *permanent and impersonal* — it let the state remember what no human could, and remember it against you. The ledger is the foundational instrument of the state, and it appears at the very beginning. Almost every later technology of control, down to the database, is a descendant of the Uruk grain tablet.

The temple and the granary as one institution. In early Mesopotamia the temple was not only a house of the god; it was the largest landowner, the central granary, the employer, the redistributor. The god owned the city; the priests managed the god's estate; the people worked the god's land and received rations. This fusion is decisive. It means that from the very start, *economic extraction and cosmic order were the same system*. To withhold your labor or your grain was not tax evasion — it was sacrilege, a tear in the fabric of the cosmos. The granary that the Neolithic aggrandizer controlled by force of personality is now controlled by the god himself, and disobedience is not defiance of a man but of the order of being.

Taxation, tribute, and the corvée. The state's defining capacity is to extract — a portion of the harvest, a share of the herd, and above all *labor*: the corvée, the obligation to work on the ruler's projects. The pyramids, the ziggurats, the canals and walls were built on conscripted labor, and that labor is the surplus of Era 2 made compulsory and monumental. The forager who could walk away now owes a season of digging to a king he will never see.

The ruler–priest pairing and the divine charter. The single greatest problem for any system of archy is *legitimacy*: why should the many obey the few, when the many vastly outnumber them and once collectively dominated any upstart? Naked force cannot sustain rule — there are never enough soldiers, and soldiers themselves must be given a reason. The early states solved this with the most powerful idea in the political history of the species: the ruler is divine, or divinely chosen. The Egyptian pharaoh *was* a god, the living Horus, the guarantor of *ma'at* — cosmic order, justice, the rising of the sun and the flooding of the Nile. The Mesopotamian king ruled as the god's chosen steward. To resist was not rebellion but chaos, the unmaking of the world.

This is the deep inversion promised at the end of Era 2. The forager leveling ideology held that no one should rise above the group; the god-king ideology holds that one man *embodies* the group, the cosmos, and the divine, so that obedience to him *is* membership in the order of

things. The same human impulse toward unity and belonging that once kept everyone equal is captured and turned into the keystone of inequality. The leveling mechanism is not merely defeated — it is reversed and conscripted.

Debt: the recorded chain, and the device that broke it

Here the story acquires its most modern-feeling thread. The same writing that recorded grain recorded **debt** — and debt is arguably the most important single mechanism in this entire history, because it is the device that converts a temporary misfortune into permanent bondage *with the victim's own consent*.

The mechanism is brutally simple and recurs for the next four thousand years. A farmer has a bad year; he borrows grain or silver to survive or to pay his tax; the loan carries interest (Mesopotamian rates were savage); he cannot repay; the creditor takes his collateral — first his oxen, then his land, then his children sold into debt-servitude, then the farmer himself. The anthropologist David Graeber argued that debt, not barter, is the true origin of money and markets, and that debt-bondage is the original and most persistent engine of the unfree labor that runs through all later history. Crucially, debt *moralizes* extraction: the debtor agreed, the debtor owes, the debtor's suffering is the debtor's own fault. It is a far cheaper tool of domination than force, because it recruits the victim's own sense of obligation.

What makes the early Near East so revealing is that the rulers *understood this dynamic and intervened against it* — not from compassion but from cold political sense. When too many farmers fell into debt-bondage, the productive population that paid taxes and served in the army was hollowed out, and the wealth and people drained into the hands of private creditors who rivaled the throne. So the kings periodically declared **debt cancellations**: the Mesopotamian *clean slate* or *(an)durarum*, in which non-commercial debts were annulled, debt-slaves freed, and forfeited land returned to its original holders. A new king often proclaimed one on taking the throne. The Hebrew **Jubilee** of Leviticus — every fiftieth year, debts forgiven, bondsmen freed, ancestral land restored — is the same institution rendered as sacred law, the word *deror* a direct cognate of the Akkadian *durarum*.

The jubilee is one of the most important facts in this document, for three reasons. It proves the ancients *knew* their economy generated bondage as a matter of structure, not accident. It shows that the response was not to abolish the debt mechanism but to *periodically reset* it — to relieve the pressure without dismantling the machine. And it establishes the deep pattern of all later history: archy generates a counter-current of relief and resistance, and that counter-current is itself often managed from above, a safety valve that preserves the system by venting its worst pressures. The leveling impulse of Era 1 survives here, but no longer as the band ridiculing a booster — now as a *king* periodically freeing the debtors, having first presided over the system that bound them.

The crucial counter-cases: states without kings

If Mesopotamia and Egypt were the whole story, inevitability would win by default. They are not. The same period offers societies that built cities, surplus, and complexity *without* the god-king package, and these break the chain.

The **Indus Valley civilization** (Harappa, Mohenjo-daro; c. 2600–1900 BCE) was vast — bigger in area than Egypt or Mesopotamia — with sophisticated planned cities, standardized weights, advanced sanitation, and long-distance trade. Yet it has yielded no convincing palaces, no royal tombs, no monumental depictions of rulers, no grand individual burials, no clear iconography of a king at all. Its undeciphered script and conspicuous absence of glorified individuals have led a number of archaeologists to argue it was organized on a strikingly different and more corporate or distributed basis. Whatever it was, it was *not* a god-king state, and it lasted for centuries.

Early Chinese civilization followed its own path and its own timing. The **Shang** (c. 1600–1046 BCE) were a powerful sacrificial-warrior monarchy whose kings communicated with royal ancestors through oracle-bone divination — a different sacral logic from Egypt's, with authority running through the ancestral line rather than through the king's own divinity, and underwritten by large-scale human sacrifice. The succeeding **Zhou** then produced one of the most consequential legitimating ideas in world history, the **Mandate of Heaven**: Heaven grants the right to rule to the just, and *withdraws* it from the cruel, so that a dynasty's overthrow proves it had already lost the Mandate. This was a sacral charter for kingship like the others — but with a revolutionary clause built in, because it made rule *conditional on conduct* and supplied, for all later Chinese history, a ready-made justification for rebellion against a tyrant. Sacralization here cut both ways.

And in the Americas, complexity was emerging on a completely independent track — the Norte Chico/Caral sites on the Peruvian coast (c. 3000 BCE and after) raising monumental platform mounds, and the Olmec of Mesoamerica (from c. 1500 BCE) carving the colossal stone heads that probably depict rulers. Independent invention of monumental hierarchy on a separate continent tells us the *pathway* is a recurrent human possibility — but the Indus contrast on the same timeline tells us it was never the only one.

What this era establishes

The first states convert the *available* hierarchy of the Neolithic into a *self-reproducing institution*, and they do it with four tools — the ledger, the temple-granary, compulsory extraction, and the divine charter — that together solve hierarchy's two chronic weaknesses: memory (the ledger remembers obligation forever) and legitimacy (the god makes obedience sacred). Debt emerges as the master-mechanism of bondage, and the jubilee as the master-mechanism of managed relief. And the counter-cases — Indus, the conditional Mandate, the varied Americas — establish that even at this threshold there was no single road. But where the god-king package *did* lock in, it would prove almost unimaginably durable, the template for kingship for the next three thousand years.

Era 4 — Classical empires and slavery

c. 800 BCE – 500 CE: codified law, coinage, mass slavery, and citizenship as graded belonging

The classical world did not invent archy, but it *systematized* it — gave it written law, abstract money, philosophical justification, and an industrial scale of human bondage. Where the god-king ruled by being the cosmos, the classical empires increasingly ruled through *institutions that outlasted any ruler*: a body of law, a coinage, a citizenship, a slave system. Power became less a person and more a structure, which is why so much of the classical apparatus feels eerily continuous with our own.

Law: the double edge of writing it down

The early states had decrees; the classical world produced **codified law** — comprehensive, public, written rules. The trajectory runs from Hammurabi's stele (c. 1754 BCE, strictly pre-classical but the ancestor) through Solon's reforms at Athens, the Roman **Twelve Tables** (c. 451 BCE), and ultimately the vast edifice of Roman jurisprudence that would be compiled in Justinian's *Corpus Juris Civilis* and shape European law for two millennia.

Codified law cuts both ways, and that ambivalence is the point. On one edge, writing the law down *limits* arbitrary power: the rule is public, predictable, the same on Tuesday as on Monday, and even the powerful can be held to it. The Roman plebeians demanded the Twelve Tables precisely so that patrician magistrates could no longer simply invent the law against them. Law is, in this aspect, a descendant of the leveling impulse — a check on the strong. On the other edge, codified law *entrenches* hierarchy by giving it the majesty and permanence of writing: Roman law meticulously defined the gradations of person and the absolute property of the master in the slave, encoding subordination as eternal legal fact rather than mere custom. The same instrument that restrains the powerful also legitimates and stabilizes their power. This double edge will reappear in every later legal order, including our own constitutions.

Coinage: abstract, impersonal, universal power

Around the seventh century BCE, in Lydia and the Greek world, and independently in China and India, came **coined money** — standardized stamped metal, guaranteed by the state, usable by anyone. Its consequences for archy are profound and underappreciated.

Coinage makes wealth *abstract, portable, anonymous, and infinitely accumulable*. A granary of barley rots and is tied to a place; a hoard of silver coin is liquid power that can be moved, hidden, lent at interest, and piled up without limit. Coinage also vastly extends the reach of debt — the master-mechanism of Era 3 — by making it precisely calculable and universally enforceable. And coinage and empire grew together in a self-feeding loop that Graeber called

the *military-coinage-slavery complex*: the state mints coin to pay soldiers; it requires taxes be paid back in that coin, forcing everyone into the market to obtain it; soldiers spend coin on plunder including slaves; slaves work the mines that produce the metal for more coin. Money, war, and bondage became a single integrated machine for converting human beings and territory into liquid, accumulable power.

Mass slavery: archy at industrial scale

Slavery existed before — debt-bondage in Mesopotamia, captives on the Northwest Coast — but classical Greece and Rome made it the *structural foundation of the economy and of citizen life itself*. These were **genuine slave societies**, not merely societies that had slaves: a large fraction of the population was chattel — legally a thing, a "speaking tool" in the Roman phrase, owned absolutely, bought and sold, worked in mines and on the great estates (*latifundia*) and in households. Rome's wars of conquest were also vast slave-harvesting operations, funneling captives by the hundreds of thousands into Italy.

The intellectual move that accompanied this is one of the darkest in the history of ideas. Aristotle, in the *Politics*, argued that some people are **slaves by nature** — beings who lack the full rational faculty and are therefore *better off* governed by a master, for whom slavery is fitting and even beneficial. This is the first great theory of *natural* hierarchy: the claim that subordination reflects a real, inborn difference of kind, that the order of domination maps onto the order of nature. It is the ancestor of every later doctrine — racial, gendered, civilizational — that justifies the power of one group over another by appeal to their essential nature. The god-king said *obey because I am divine*; Aristotle says *obey because you are, by nature, the kind of thing that is ruled*. The second claim is more insidious because it locates the justification inside the dominated themselves.

The counter-current was present but weak. Spartacus's revolt (73–71 BCE) terrified Rome but sought escape, not abolition; no classical movement proposed ending slavery as such. The Stoics developed a striking idea of inner freedom and the brotherhood of all rational beings — Epictetus, who had himself been a slave, taught that the master can chain the body but never the will — yet Stoicism preached endurance and inner liberty rather than the overthrow of the institution. The horizon of *abolition* did not yet exist. This absence is itself important: it shows that even a brilliant civilization can find a monstrous institution simply unquestionable, naturalized so completely that the alternative is unthinkable. The leveling impulse had been not just defeated but *philosophized out of view*.

Citizenship: belonging as a hierarchy

The classical world's most enduring contribution to the architecture of archy may be the idea that *belonging itself is ranked*. Athenian democracy — radical and real for those inside it — drew a hard line: adult male citizens governed; women, resident foreigners (*metics*), and the enslaved majority did not. The democracy of the few rested on the labor and exclusion of the many, and the equality inside the citizen body was inseparable from the inequality at its edge.

Rome turned this into a sophisticated, *graded* system. Citizenship was not binary but a ladder of statuses — full citizen, Latin right, freedman, provincial subject, slave — each with different bundles of rights, and movement up the ladder was possible (a freed slave's son could be a citizen; the Edict of Caracalla in 212 CE extended citizenship to nearly all free inhabitants of the empire). This was genuinely more flexible than caste, but it established a template of immense and lasting power: the sorting of human beings into legal tiers of belonging, with rights attached to tier rather than to humanity. The modern world's passports, immigration categories, and citizenship regimes are the direct institutional descendants. Citizenship is the velvet form of archy — it can feel like inclusion to those inside while functioning as exclusion at the boundary.

The Eastern parallel: Han China and the bureaucratic alternative

Contemporary with Rome, **Han China** (206 BCE – 220 CE) ran an empire of comparable scale on a strikingly different principle, and the contrast illuminates what is contingent in the Western path. Where Rome rested on slave latifundia and a citizen-soldier ideology, the Han governed through a *centralized bureaucracy* staffed increasingly by men selected for their mastery of texts — the embryo of the examination system that would later become the famous meritocratic civil service. Confucian ideology legitimated hierarchy not through a slave/free binary or a divine king but through a web of *reciprocal but unequal duties*: ruler and minister, father and son, husband and wife, each relationship binding both parties but never as equals. Subordination was framed as harmony, role, and mutual obligation rather than ownership.

This matters for the inevitability question because it shows the classical solution to large-scale order was *plural*. Hierarchy was universal across the Eurasian empires, but its *technology* and *justification* varied profoundly — chattel slavery and codified property in the West, bureaucratic office and reciprocal Confucian duty in the East, the Persian Achaemenid model of a "king of kings" presiding tolerantly over a mosaic of subject peoples in between. Same outcome — the power of the few over the many at imperial scale — reached by genuinely different roads, which means no single road was *the* road.

What this era establishes

The classical empires depersonalize archy. Power moves from the body of the god-king into durable institutions — law, coin, citizenship, the slave system — that run regardless of who sits on the throne, and that prove able to operate at a scale of millions. Three inventions here are permanent additions to the repertoire: *abstract money* (limitless, liquid, accumulable power), *natural-hierarchy theory* (subordination as inborn fact), and *graded citizenship* (belonging as rank). Slavery reaches an industrial scale and acquires a philosophy. And the counter-current narrows to almost nothing — endurance, inner freedom, the occasional desperate revolt — with the very idea of abolition still below the horizon. That horizon will not open for another thousand years and more, and when it does it will be against a slavery even larger and crueler than Rome's.

Era 5 — Feudal and tributary orders

c. 500 – 1450: land-bound labor, divine right, and the many faces of the unfree

After the western Roman state dissolved, archy in much of Eurasia took a recognizable new shape: power devolved, fragmented, and *localized*, attaching itself directly to land and to the bodies that worked it. The grand impersonal machinery of the classical empire — the standing bureaucracy, the universal coinage, the codified law reaching every province — receded in the European west, and into the vacuum came a more intimate, more personal, and in some ways more total form of domination. The defining fact of this whole era, across very different civilizations, is the **binding of labor to land**: the worker is no longer chattel that can be sold away, but neither is he free to leave. The forager's ultimate weapon — exit, the right to walk away — is abolished not by selling the person but by *fixing him to the soil*.

This part deliberately ranges beyond Europe, because the European manor is only one species of a genus that appeared, with local logic, across the medieval world.

European feudalism and serfdom

The classic model — never as tidy in reality as in the textbook — was a pyramid of *personal* bonds. The king granted land (a fief) to great lords in exchange for military service and loyalty; lords sub-granted to lesser knights; at the base, the **serf** worked the lord's manor. The serf was not a slave: he could not be sold as an individual, he held customary rights to work strips of land and to the protection of his lord, he had a family and a household the law recognized. But he *was bound to the manor* — he could not leave without permission, owed days of labor on the lord's demesne (the descendant of the corvée), paid dues in kind and later in cash, and was subject to the lord's court. He was, in the precise medieval phrase, *adscriptus glebae* — written into the soil, transferred with the land when it changed hands.

The legitimating ideology was the doctrine of the **three orders**: those who pray (*oratores* — clergy), those who fight (*bellatores* — nobility), and those who work (*laboratores* — everyone else). This was presented as a divinely ordained division of function in which each order served the others — the peasant fed the knight who protected him and the priest who prayed for his soul. It is the Confucian logic of reciprocal-but-unequal duty in Christian dress, and like all the great legitimations it converted raw extraction into cosmic harmony and mutual obligation. Above the whole structure sat the **divine right of kings**: the monarch answerable to God alone, the direct descendant of the god-king charter of Era 3, persisting essentially unbroken from Sumer to Versailles.

The Church was not outside this system but central to it — itself a vast landlord with its own serfs, the ideological author of the three orders, and the keeper of the keys to salvation, which gave it a coercive power over the medieval mind at least as great as the lord's power over the body. Heaven and hell are, among other things, instruments of social control: the promise that

earthly subordination would be rewarded, and earthly rebellion punished, in an eternity that no one could verify but everyone feared.

The same problem solved elsewhere: the genus of tributary power

The European arrangement was one local answer to a problem every complex agrarian society faced — how a small armed-and-literate elite extracts a surplus from a large peasant majority. Naming the parallel answers is essential, both to avoid Eurocentrism and to see what is structural rather than peculiar.

Japan developed, largely independently, a strikingly convergent system. By the time of the shogunate, real power lay with a military aristocracy — the *daimyō* lords and their *samurai* retainers — bound by codes of loyalty and service strongly analogous to European vassalage, presiding over peasants tied to the land and the village, with an emperor reduced to a sacral figurehead. That two civilizations with almost no contact produced such similar structures is strong evidence that *this configuration is a recurrent solution* to the agrarian-extraction problem, not a cultural accident.

The **Islamic world** ran a different and often more centralized variant. Rather than hereditary fiefs, many Islamic states used the *iqṭāʿ* — a grant of the right to collect the tax revenue of a district, assigned to a soldier or official in lieu of salary, in principle revocable and non-hereditary, which kept power flowing through the state rather than congealing into an independent landed nobility. Strikingly, some of these states ran on **military slavery** — the *mamlūk* and later Ottoman *devshirme* systems, in which boys were taken, converted, and trained into elite slave-soldiers and administrators who could rise to the very pinnacle of power, even to rule. A "slave" who commands armies and governs provinces explodes any simple notion of what bondage means: status here was a matter of *belonging to the ruler's household* rather than of degradation, a logic almost unintelligible in Roman or later Atlantic terms, and a reminder that "slavery" names very different institutions in different systems.

India's structure was the most distinctive and, in one respect, the most extreme: the **caste system** (*varna* and the thousands of local *jāti*). Here social hierarchy was not merely heritable but *ritually sacralized as a cosmic order of purity and pollution*, fixed at birth, regulating whom one could marry, eat with, and what work one must do, and underwritten by religious doctrines of *dharma* (duty appropriate to one's station) and rebirth (one's birth-station reflecting deeds in past lives). Caste is the most thoroughgoing *naturalization* of hierarchy in human history — more total than Aristotle's natural slavery, because it embeds rank in the structure of the cosmos and the soul's own karmic history, making subordination not just natural but *deserved across lifetimes*. The leveling impulse faces, here, its most formidable ideological adversary: a system in which to resist your station is to defy the moral order of the universe itself.

The peasant economy and the counter-currents

Across all these systems the underlying reality was a **tributary mode**: peasants produced, and a portion was extracted upward as rent, tax, tribute, labor, or some blend, to support a

non-producing elite of warriors, priests, and officials. The mechanisms of Era 3 — extraction, sacralization, the binding of labor — persisted; what changed was their *localization* (power attached to land and lord rather than to a distant capital) and the *form of unfreedom* (bound rather than owned).

But the leveling impulse was never extinguished, and the medieval world saw it flare repeatedly. **Peasant revolts** punctuate the era — the English Rising of 1381, the German Peasants' War of 1525, the *jacqueries* of France, the Red Turban and countless other risings in China — often explicitly egalitarian, demanding the abolition of serfdom and sometimes invoking a radical theology: the famous English question "*When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?*" — if we all descend from one couple who worked the earth with their own hands, where did lords come from? This is the leveling ethos of Era 1, surfacing across ten thousand years, now armed with scripture: the claim that hierarchy is a human imposition, not a divine or natural fact, that there was an original equality and the lords are usurpers of it. Most revolts were crushed, but they register the permanent presence of the egalitarian counter-current even under the most sacralized hierarchies.

And then, in the European case, came a demographic accident with vast structural consequences. The **Black Death** (1347–51) killed perhaps a third to half of Europe's people, and by making labor suddenly scarce it gave the surviving peasants enormous bargaining power. Lords who needed workers had to compete for them; wages rose, dues fell, and across much of Western Europe serfdom *withered* over the following centuries — not primarily through revolt but through the silent leverage of a labor shortage. The forager's lost weapon, exit, partially returned: when labor is scarce and mobile, the bound worker can again, in effect, threaten to leave, and the binding loosens. (In Eastern Europe, by contrast, lords responded to the same pressures by *tightening* serfdom — the "second serfdom" — a divergence that shaped the continent for centuries and warns against assuming any single direction to history.) This is a profound structural lesson that will recur in Era 7: **the relative scarcity or abundance of labor is one of the deepest determinants of how much the powerful can extract**, often more decisive than ideology or law.

What this era establishes

The feudal-tributary millennium shows archy *localizing* and *personalizing* after the fall of the classical megastate, binding labor to land across civilizations through convergent but distinct institutions — European serfdom, Japanese vassalage, the Islamic *iqṭāʿ* and military slavery, Indian caste. It demonstrates, through that convergence, that the small-elite-extracting-from-a-peasant-majority structure is a recurrent solution rather than a cultural quirk. It shows ideology reaching its maximum naturalizing power in caste. And it reveals two engines of the counter-current that will dominate the modern story: the recurring egalitarian revolt with its memory of an original equality, and the brute leverage of *labor scarcity*, which can loosen the chains without anyone intending it. As this era closes, Europe — newly freed of serfdom in its west, hungry for the silver that pays its debts, and armed with ships — is

about to take its hierarchies global, and to invent a form of bondage worse than anything yet seen.

Era 6 — Mercantilism, colonialism, and the Atlantic system

c. 1450 – 1800: the joint-stock company, racialized slavery, and power going global

From roughly 1450 a regional story becomes a planetary one. European powers, propelled by ship technology, gunpowder, the hunger for silver to settle their debts and buy Asian goods, and a Christianity that licensed conquest of the "heathen," built the first genuinely *global* system of extraction. Archy now operates across oceans and continents, links the silver mines of the Andes to the spice ports of Asia to the sugar islands of the Caribbean, and invents two devices of staggering and lasting consequence: the **corporation** as an engine of impersonal accumulation, and **racialized chattel slavery** as a system of bondage justified by a newly invented hierarchy of human kinds.

The joint-stock company: archy without a body, accountability without a soul

The instrument that made global extraction possible was a legal-financial innovation whose importance is hard to overstate: the **joint-stock chartered company**, above all the English and Dutch East India Companies (founded 1600 and 1602). It solved a specific problem — how to assemble the enormous capital and bear the enormous risk of long-distance armed trade — by *pooling* investment from many shareholders, who owned tradable shares and enjoyed limited liability, and by *persisting* as an entity beyond the lives of its members.

The consequences for the structure of power were revolutionary, and they point straight at our own age. The company is an *immortal, impersonal accumulator* — it never dies, never tires, has no body to imprison and no soul to damn, and exists for the single purpose of returning profit to its shareholders. It separated *ownership from management* (shareholders owned; directors ran it), creating a structure where the people who controlled the machine were not personally the people who owned it, and neither bore the full human consequences of what the machine did. And the great companies were granted *sovereign powers* — the East India Companies could wage war, sign treaties, coin money, administer territory, and keep standing armies. A private profit-seeking corporation became, in effect, a state: the English East India Company conquered and ruled the Indian subcontinent for a century before the British Crown took over. This is a new kind of archy — power exercised not by a king or a class of nobles but by a *legal abstraction* optimized for accumulation, dispersing moral responsibility across thousands of distant shareholders who simply received a dividend. We will meet its lineal descendant, the modern transnational corporation, in Era 8.

Mercantilism and the logic of extraction

The governing economic doctrine, **mercantilism**, held that national wealth was finite (measured in bullion) and that the state should maximize its share — promoting exports, hoarding silver and gold, and above all acquiring *colonies* as captive sources of raw materials and captive markets for finished goods. The colony existed for the metropole; its economy was deliberately structured to extract value outward. This is the tributary logic of Era 5 rescaled to the planet: the colony stands to the imperial center as the peasant stood to the lord, producing a surplus pumped upward and outward. The silver of Potosí — mined under the brutal *mita* forced-labor draft imposed on Andean communities, itself a colonial perversion of an older Inca labor obligation — flowed to Spain and on to China, financing European power with American minerals dug by coerced American hands.

Racialized chattel slavery: the catastrophe and its novelty

At the center of the Atlantic system sat the largest forced migration in human history and one of its greatest crimes: the **transatlantic slave trade**, which tore an estimated twelve million or more Africans from their homes and shipped them across the Atlantic — perhaps one and a half to two million dying in the Middle Passage alone — to labor and die on the plantations of the Americas. The sugar, tobacco, coffee, and cotton that built European and American wealth were grown by enslaved people worked, on the sugar islands especially, to death and replaced by fresh purchases.

It is essential to see what was *new* here, because slavery was ancient. Three features made Atlantic slavery distinct and, in its specific cruelty, unprecedented.

First, its **scale and economic centrality** — this was slavery as the engine of a transcontinental capitalist economy, integrated with global finance, insurance, shipping, and manufacturing, not a domestic or incidental institution but the productive heart of the whole Atlantic system.

Second, its **heritable, perpetual, total chattel character** — the enslaved and *all their descendants forever* were property, with virtually no path to freedom and no recognized personhood, a more absolute and more permanent bondage than the debt-slavery of Mesopotamia (which the jubilee released) or even Roman slavery (where manumission was common and a freedman's son could be a citizen).

Third, and most consequentially for everything after, its **justification by race**. Earlier slavery was largely the fortune of war or debt — anyone might fall into it, and it carried no theory that the enslaved were a different *kind* of human. Atlantic slavery, confronting the awkward contradiction between Christian universalism, emerging Enlightenment talk of natural rights, and the brute fact of chattel bondage, generated a monstrous resolution: the *invention of race*. The idea that humanity divides into biologically distinct ranked groups, that Africans were a naturally inferior kind suited to servitude, was elaborated precisely to square the circle — to let people who proclaimed liberty and human dignity hold other human beings as property. **Race is, in**

significant part, a product of slavery rather than its cause — an ideology built to justify an economic system, then outliving it by centuries. This is Aristotle's natural-slavery doctrine (Era 4) reborn in pseudo-biological form and welded to skin color, and it became the most poisonous and durable hierarchy-justifying idea of the modern world, structuring societies long after the slavery that birthed it was abolished.

The great inversion: the counter-current finally crosses the abolition horizon

And here, for the first time in this entire history, the counter-current does something genuinely new. Recall that classical antiquity could not even *imagine* abolishing slavery (Era 4) — the institution was below the horizon of the thinkable. In the later eighteenth century that horizon opened. A broad **abolition movement** arose — Quakers and other dissenting Christians, formerly enslaved writers and activists like Olaudah Equiano whose own testimony pierced the comfortable abstraction, Enlightenment philosophers turning natural-rights logic against the slavery their contemporaries practiced — and for the first time a mass movement declared that slavery was not a regrettable necessity or a natural fact but an *abomination to be ended everywhere*.

It did not succeed by moral argument alone, and honesty requires saying so. The single greatest blow against Atlantic slavery was struck by the enslaved themselves: the **Haitian Revolution** (1791–1804), in which the enslaved people of the richest plantation colony on earth rose, defeated the armies of France, Spain, and Britain, and founded a free state — the only instance in history of a slave revolt creating a nation. Haiti made vivid what Spartacus could not: that the enslaved could not merely flee but *win*, and that the natural-hierarchy ideology was a lie the dominated could disprove with their own hands. The combination of slave resistance, abolitionist mobilization, shifting economic interest, and revolutionary ideology drove the long nineteenth-century dismantling of legal slavery across the Atlantic world — Britain's trade ban (1807) and emancipation (1833), the U.S. Civil War (1865), Brazil last in the Americas (1888).

This is the most important single development in the modern history of archy, and it deserves to be marked as such. After at least five thousand years in which the great hierarchies were periodically *relieved* (the jubilee) or *fled* (Spartacus, the maroon communities) but never *abolished in principle*, a form of bondage as old as civilization was, across roughly a century, declared illegitimate and largely dismantled. The leveling impulse of Era 1 — never extinguished, surfacing in every peasant revolt — at last achieved escape velocity, generating not just relief but the *idea that a whole category of domination must end*. That idea, once loosed, would not stay confined to slavery; it would turn next on the wage-labor system that the very same era was building, and on every other inherited hierarchy of rank, race, and sex.

What this era establishes

The Atlantic centuries globalize archy and give it two of its most consequential modern instruments: the *corporation* — immortal, impersonal, accountability-dispersing, sometimes sovereign, optimized purely for accumulation — and *race* — a hierarchy of human kinds invented to justify a slavery more total than any before it. Power now operates at planetary scale

through legal abstractions and pseudo-biological ideology. But the same era opens, for the first time in the species' history, the *abolition horizon*: the genuinely novel idea, proven on the battlefield of Haiti and in the abolitionist movement, that an entire ancient form of domination can be not merely relieved or escaped but *ended*. The next era will be defined by the collision between an industrial capitalism inheriting these instruments and a counter-current that has finally learned it can win.

Era 7 — Industrial capitalism

c. 1800 – 1970: wage labor, the factory, the nation-state, and the century the counter-current won its greatest victories

Industrialization transformed the *form* of archy more profoundly than anything since the first states, and it did so while the abolition horizon opened in Era 6 was widening into a general assault on inherited hierarchy of every kind. This era is therefore a genuine collision — the most concentrated machinery of extraction yet built, met by the most powerful organized resistance yet mounted. To tell it as either triumph or tragedy is to miss it; it is both at once, and the tension between them is the point.

The new form of domination: free labor, unfree conditions

The defining novelty is **wage labor** as the dominant relation of production, and its novelty is genuinely puzzling at first. The industrial worker was, unlike the slave or the serf, legally *free* — free to quit, to move, to sell his labor to whomever he chose, owning himself entirely. The chains of Parts 4 through 6 — chattel ownership, binding to the soil — were gone. So where is the archy?

It lies in the structure the political economists of the age, and Marx most penetratingly, exposed. The worker is free in person but *separated from the means of production* — he owns no land, no workshop, no machine, nothing he can live from except his capacity to work. The factory, the tools, the raw materials are owned by the capitalist. So the worker's "freedom" is the freedom to sell his labor *or starve*: he must take employment on whatever terms are offered, because the alternative is destitution. This is the granary coercion of Era 2 in its purest and most abstract form — control of the means of subsistence translating into control of the people who lack them — but now achieved *without* legal bondage, through the seemingly neutral mechanism of a voluntary contract between formally equal parties. The domination is real but it is *masked by the form of free exchange*, which is precisely what makes it so durable and so hard to attack: no one owns the worker, no law binds him, and yet the structural compulsion to submit is nearly as total as serfdom. Where the feudal lord said *you may not leave*, the factory says *you may leave whenever you like — and go where?*

The **factory** itself was a new technology of control as much as of production. It gathered workers under one roof, under the discipline of the clock, the bell, the assembly line, and the foreman's eye, subordinating the rhythms of the human body to the tireless rhythm of the machine. The craftsman who had owned his tools and set his own pace became the operative who served a machine he did not own at a pace he did not set. A century later this would be intensified into a science: **Taylorism**, "scientific management," which broke work into timed, deskilled fragments and concentrated all knowledge and decision in management — stripping the worker of autonomy and judgment, reducing him as far as possible to an interchangeable, controllable component. The deskilling is itself a strategy of power: a worker who knows only one fragment is easily replaced and hard to organize.

The nation-state: archy's modern container

The political container for all this was the **modern nation-state**, which over the nineteenth and twentieth centuries became vastly more capable than any previous form of rule — and that growing capacity cut, as always, both ways. The state acquired the ability to count, track, school, conscript, tax, and police its population with unprecedented thoroughness: the census, the passport, compulsory mass education, the standing bureaucracy, the police force, eventually the fingerprint and the identity card. The historian and anthropologist James C. Scott described this as the state's drive to make society "**legible**" — to reorganize a messy, illegible human world into standardized, countable, controllable units (fixed surnames, standardized measures, gridded cities, cadastral maps) that a central authority can see and therefore govern. Legibility is the ledger of Era 3 grown to encompass the entire population: the state that can see you can tax, conscript, and discipline you. The same capacities, turned to their darkest extreme in the twentieth century, enabled totalitarian control and industrialized genocide — the modern state's power to know and organize its people is also the power that made the Holocaust administratively possible.

And **nationalism** supplied the legitimating ideology, the heir to the divine charter and the three orders. It recast the population not as subjects of a dynasty but as a *people*, a nation with a shared identity and destiny, binding the individual to the state through identity and belonging rather than through naked coercion — and, like classical citizenship (Era 4), defining the nation always *against* outsiders, so that belonging and exclusion were again two sides of one coin. Nationalism could be emancipatory (it powered anti-colonial liberation) and murderous (it powered the World Wars and ethnic cleansing), often at once.

The counter-current at full force: the century of organized resistance

Here is where this era earns its place as the great collision, because the same industrial conditions that concentrated workers in factories and cities also *concentrated their power to resist*, and the abolition horizon of Era 6 widened into a general assault on hierarchy. For the first time since the foragers, the leveling impulse operated not as a doomed peasant revolt or a desperate slave flight but as *sustained, organized, partly successful mass movements* that permanently altered the structure of power. Three great currents ran together.

The **labor movement** turned the workers' one structural asset — their numbers and their indispensability — into organized force. Individually the worker faced the employer as a powerless supplicant; *combined* in a trade union, withholding labor collectively through the strike, workers discovered they could bargain. This is, in a deep sense, the reverse dominance hierarchy of Era 1 reinvented for industrial conditions: the many combining to check the power of the few, the foragers' collective leveling reborn as the union and the strike. Against ferocious resistance — troops fired on strikers, organizers were jailed and killed, unions were long illegal as criminal conspiracies — the movement won across decades the things now so normalized we forget they were *fought for and are reversible*: limits on the working day, the weekend, the abolition of child labor, workplace safety law, the minimum wage, the right to organize itself. Where labor was *scarce or organized* it could extract these concessions; where abundant or suppressed it could not — the labor-leverage lesson of Era 5's Black Death, now made the conscious basis of strategy.

The **extension of the franchise** turned the political hierarchy of citizenship (Era 4) into a terrain of struggle. The vote, once the jealously guarded privilege of propertied men, was prised open step by grudging step — to working men, then through the long and often violent **suffrage movements** to women, and through the civil rights struggles to racial minorities excluded in law or in fact. Each extension was resisted as the end of civilization and each, once won, became unthinkable to reverse. Formal political equality — one person, one vote — is a historically astonishing achievement set against the five thousand years of graded belonging that preceded it, even where its substance remained constrained by inequalities of wealth and power that voting alone could not touch.

And the broad **emancipatory movements** — the completion of *abolition* and the long subsequent struggle against its racial afterlife; the **women's movement** confronting the patriarchy that is the oldest archy of all, older than the state, predating every structure in this document and woven through all of them; the **anti-colonial movements** that after 1945 dismantled the formal empires of Era 6 and reclaimed self-rule for most of humanity — together represent the leveling impulse turning on *every* inherited hierarchy of rank, race, sex, and empire at once. The horizon that opened with the idea that slavery could be abolished kept widening until, in principle, *no* inherited domination was any longer beyond question.

The institutional settlement that emerged in the mid-twentieth-century West — the **social-democratic compromise**, the welfare state, mass unionization, progressive taxation, the partial decommmodification of health, education, and old age — represented the high-water mark of this counter-current: not the abolition of capitalist archy but its most thorough *taming*, the closest the modern world came to rebuilding, at the scale of the nation-state, something of the forager principle that no one should be allowed to fall too low or rise too far above the rest. It was, like the jubilee (Era 3), a managed relief of the system's pressures rather than a dismantling of the machine — but it was real, and its partial unwinding is the subject of the final part.

What this era establishes

Industrial capitalism produces a *masked* form of domination — real coercion through the means of subsistence, hidden behind the free and equal labor contract — and a vastly more capable *nation-state* that can see, count, and control its population as never before. But it is also the era in which the counter-current, after millennia as a losing force, mounts sustained and partly victorious mass resistance: the union and the strike reinventing collective leveling, the franchise turning citizenship into contested ground, the great emancipations turning on inherited hierarchy of every kind, and the welfare state achieving the most thorough taming of archy the large-scale world has seen. The story here is genuinely double — concentration and resistance, the ledger and the strike, advancing together. The final part asks what happened when, after about 1970, the concentrating forces found new instruments and the taming forces went into retreat.

Era 8 — The present

c. 1970 – now: financialization, globalization, algorithmic management, data as surplus — and the question "novel, or familiar?"

The final part is the hardest, because we lack the distance that turns events into history, and because the present is precisely where the inevitability and "novel-or-familiar" threads must be paid off rather than admired from afar. The organizing claim is this: since roughly 1970 the *taming* of archy achieved by the mid-century social-democratic settlement (Era 7) has substantially unwound, while the *concentrating* forces have acquired genuinely new instruments. Whether those instruments represent something unprecedented or merely the ancient mechanisms in new clothing is the question that gives this era its character — and the most useful answer, examined below, is *both*: the form is novel, the underlying logic is among the oldest in this document.

The turn: from taming back toward concentration

Around the 1970s the postwar arrangement began to reverse across much of the world: the partial decommodification of life retreated, unions were weakened by law and by the offshoring of the industrial jobs that had been their base, top tax rates fell, capital was deregulated and freed to move across borders, and the doctrine that markets should govern more and states less became orthodoxy. The measurable result is a return of wealth and income concentration toward levels not seen since before the Era 7 counter-current — the great mid-century compression of inequality has been substantially reversed in many countries.

The current numbers make the scale concrete and are worth stating plainly. On average, a person in the richest 1% owns thousands of times more wealth than someone in the bottom 50%, and the poorest half of humanity holds just over half of one percent of the world's wealth, while the richest 1% own close to 44%. The World Inequality Report 2026 found that the top

10% of the world's income earners earn more than the other 90% combined. Billionaire wealth reached roughly \$18.3 trillion in 2025, its highest level in history, having risen by around 81% since 2020, even as one in four people do not regularly have enough to eat and nearly half the world's population lives in poverty. This is not a side-effect to be noted and set aside; it is the headline structural fact of the era, the unwinding of the only large-scale taming of archy the modern world ever achieved.

Financialization: power moves upstream from production to ownership

The first novel-seeming mechanism is **financialization** — the growing dominance of finance, of the *ownership and trading of claims on wealth*, over the actual production of goods and services. Profit increasingly accrues not to those who make things but to those who own the financial claims: shares, debt, derivatives, real estate, intellectual property. This is, in one light, the purest distillation of the corporation of Era 6 and the abstract money of Era 4 — power as ownership of liquid, accumulable claims, now grown to govern the whole economy. The asset-owner extracts a flow of rent, interest, and capital gains from the productive activity of others without necessarily organizing or contributing to that activity at all.

The deepest continuity here is **debt**, the master-mechanism first met in Era 3. Household, student, medical, consumer, and sovereign debt bind populations and whole nations into obligation, and debt operates today exactly as it did in Mesopotamia: a temporary shortfall converts, through interest, into a durable claim on the debtor's future labor and assets, and it moralizes the relationship so the debtor feels the obligation as personal failing rather than structural design. The crucial difference from Era 3 is the *absence of the jubilee*. The ancient kings periodically wiped the slate clean to prevent debt from hollowing out their societies; the modern system has, for the most part, no comparable institutional reset (sovereign-debt crises and the occasional bankruptcy aside), and the question of whether a debt jubilee is needed has returned to serious discussion precisely because the ancient pressure the jubilee was designed to relieve has returned with it.

Globalization: the spatial reorganization of extraction

Globalization reorganized archy across space. Production was distributed along global supply chains to wherever labor was cheapest and least protected, which let capital escape the bargained settlement of Era 7: a factory that can relocate to a lower-wage jurisdiction holds a structural threat over any workforce that organizes, neutralizing the strike weapon that won the twentieth century's gains. This is, at bottom, the *labor-leverage* principle of Era 5's Black Death running in reverse — where a labor *shortage* once empowered the medieval peasant, the global integration of a vast low-wage labor supply *weakened* labor everywhere by making it abundant and substitutable. The colonial extraction-pattern of Era 6 also persists in modified form: despite being home to 79 percent of the world's population, Global South countries own just 31 percent of global wealth. The relation of metropole to colony has become the relation of capital-owning core to labor-supplying periphery — the tributary logic of Era 5 globalized, with value still pumped from periphery toward center.

Algorithmic management: the foreman becomes code

Here is the mechanism that feels most genuinely new, and it rewards close examination because it is where the "novel or familiar?" question bites hardest. In the **gig economy** and increasingly in warehouses, call centers, and conventional workplaces, the managerial functions once performed by human supervisors are now performed by software. On platforms like the food-delivery and ride-hailing services, algorithms operating on data captured from workers' own smartphones determine the allocation of work, the pay, the discipline, and sometimes even the termination of the worker.

Scholars have noticed the deep historical rhyme, and it is exact. Algorithmic management is argued to constitute a contemporary form of scientific management — Taylorism reborn — in which jobs are fragmented into simple repetitive tasks, the labor process is tightly controlled for maximum efficiency, and workers who underperform can be easily identified and replaced. The Taylorism of Era 7 is back, but automated, continuous, and vastly more granular: where the human foreman could watch only intermittently, the algorithm watches *always*. The irony has been noted that even as penal systems have largely abandoned Panopticon-based prison designs on ethical grounds, modern workplaces have adopted similar principles of constant observation under the banner of efficiency and optimization.

So is it novel or familiar? Both, and the structure of the "both" is the lesson. The *logic* is ancient — control through surveillance, deskilling, and the threat of replacement is Taylorism (Era 7), and behind Taylorism the factory bell, and behind the bell the foreman's eye, and behind that the overseer. The *form* is new in three ways that matter. The surveillance is now *total and continuous* rather than intermittent. The authority is *depersonalized into code*, so there is no foreman to argue with, no human whose judgment can be appealed to or whose conscience can be reached — a worker "disciplined in real-time" by an algorithm faces a wall, not a person, the corporation's dispersal of responsibility (Era 6) carried to its endpoint where *no human at all* is visibly responsible for the domination. And the worker is often *legally classified as an independent contractor* rather than an employee, which strips away the very protections the Era 7 counter-current won — no minimum wage, no collective bargaining, no safety net — while the *control* exerted is as tight as any factory's or tighter. This last move is the era's signature trick: it combines the *freedom rhetoric* of the wage contract (Era 7) — you're your own boss, you choose your hours — with a degree of control that the wage contract's critics would have recognized instantly, achieving the substance of subordination while disclaiming its form. It is the masking of domination behind free exchange, perfected.

The leveling counter-current is responding, as it always has, and the response confirms the pattern. Gig workers have developed "workaround strategies" to cope with and regain control under platform algorithms, and have built external alliances and digital tools to resist and protect themselves from algorithmic control and surveillance — a repertoire scholars classify as manipulation, subversion, and disruption. This is the reverse dominance hierarchy of Era 1 and

the union of Era 7 reaching for new tools against a new form of the old domination — collective resistance reinventing itself once more, now against an adversary made of code.

Data as surplus: a candidate for the genuinely new

If anything in the present is truly unprecedented, it may be this. The era's defining resource is **data**, and the relation built on it — variously called surveillance capitalism — has a structure with no exact precedent in the preceding seven parts. Human behavior itself, recorded as data exhaust from everything we do online and increasingly offline, becomes raw material: captured, often without meaningful consent or awareness, refined by machine learning into predictions about what we will do, and sold — chiefly, so far, to those who want to influence our purchasing and our voting.

Why might this be genuinely novel rather than another old mechanism in new dress? Every prior form of extraction in this document took something *external* — the harvest, the labor of the body, the silver in the ground, the hours at the machine. Data extraction takes the *record of behavior itself*, including behavior we don't experience as labor or as a transaction at all, and turns the prediction and *modification* of behavior into the product. The surplus being accumulated is, in a sense, a slice of human experience and autonomy. It concentrates in a handful of firms an asymmetry of knowledge-about-people unlike anything a god-king or a factory owner ever possessed: they know an enormous amount about each of us, and we know almost nothing about their systems — an information asymmetry that is itself a profound and new form of power, the ledger of Era 3 grown to encompass not just what we owe but what we are likely to *do*.

Yet even here the familiar reasserts itself, and intellectual honesty requires holding both. The *underlying drive* — to know the population in order to govern and extract from it — is exactly the state's drive toward "legibility" (Era 7) and behind it the ledger of Era 3. Data is the Uruk grain tablet's most distant descendant: a technology for *seeing* people so as to extract from them. What is new is the totality, the granularity, the privatization (this legibility belongs to corporations as much as states), and above all the turn from recording the past to *predicting and shaping the future*. So the most defensible verdict on the whole era is the one the question itself invites: the present is the oldest mechanisms — extraction, debt, surveillance, the masking of coercion as free exchange, the dispersal of responsibility — running on radically new infrastructure that changes their scale, their speed, their totality, and in the single case of behavioral data, arguably their *kind*.

What this era establishes

The present is the unwinding of the twentieth century's taming of archy and the re-concentration of wealth and power toward pre-counter-current levels, achieved through financialization (power as ownership of liquid claims, with debt as the master-mechanism and *no jubilee*), globalization (extraction reorganized across space, labor weakened by its own global abundance), algorithmic management (Taylorist control perfected — total, continuous, depersonalized into code, and combined with the stripping-away of hard-won protections), and data extraction (the

candidate for the genuinely new — the capture of behavior itself as surplus). The recurring answer to "novel or familiar?" is *both*: novel forms, ancient logics. And the leveling counter-current, never extinct since the foragers, is once again reaching for new tools against a new face of the old domination.

Synthesis: the mechanisms, the verdict, and the counter-current

Having walked the eight eras, we can now extract what was promised at the outset — not a single thesis but a map of the recurring devices by which the power of one human over another is generated, and an honest answer to the two framing questions.

The recurring mechanisms of archy

Across thirty thousand years, the same small set of devices reappears in era after era, each time in new dress. Naming them together makes the structure visible.

Control of the means of subsistence. The oldest and deepest mechanism. The forager sharing economy was engineered to deny anyone this power; the Neolithic granary first supplied it; the temple-state institutionalized it; industrial capitalism abstracted it into the wage relation ("work or starve"); the present extends it through debt and the platform. Whoever controls what others need to live can command them, and almost every form of archy reduces, at bottom, to some version of this.

Debt. The master-mechanism, because it achieves domination *with the victim's consent and self-blame*. It appears fully formed in Mesopotamia, is periodically reset by the jubilee, is supercharged by coinage, runs through colonial and industrial bondage, and dominates the financialized present — now without the jubilee. Debt is the cheapest tool of power because it recruits the debtor's own sense of obligation.

The ledger. The technology of memory and legibility. Writing was invented to track what people owe; the state's power has always rested on its ability to see its population (census, map, surname, passport); the present extends this to the total, predictive surveillance of data extraction. To be seen by power is to be governable by it.

Sacralization and naturalization. The solution to legitimacy — the chronic problem that the many outnumber the few. The god-king *embodies* the cosmos; the three orders and Confucian duty make hierarchy *harmonious*; caste makes it *karmic*; Aristotle and race make it *natural* and inborn. The most durable hierarchies are those that convince the dominated their subordination reflects the order of the universe or their own essential nature.

The dispersal of responsibility. The corporation (Era 6) made power impersonal and immortal, separating those who own from those who manage from those who suffer, so that no individual

need feel responsible for what the structure does. Algorithmic management (Era 8) carries this to its endpoint, dissolving the responsible human entirely into code. Diffusing accountability is itself a technology of power.

The masking of coercion as free exchange. The subtlest mechanism, perfected late. The wage contract (Era 7) achieves real subordination through a form that looks like a free agreement between equals; the gig platform (Era 8) perfects the trick, combining the rhetoric of autonomy with the substance of total control. Domination is most stable when it does not look like domination.

The abolition of exit. Running beneath all of these is the loss of the forager's ultimate check — the right to walk away. Sedentism took it (Era 2), serfdom abolished it by binding labor to land (Era 5), the wage system replaced it with "leave and go where?" (Era 7), and globalization turned it against labor by giving *capital* the mobility that workers lack (Era 8). Watch the right to leave, and you can read the rise of archy in any era.

The chain in short form

These mechanisms can be read as a single causal chain — not a sequence of *added* oppressions but a sequence of *removed defenses*, each link stripping away one of the things that kept foragers equal. The links are cumulative rather than strictly chronological: once a link is added it rarely disappears, so a modern worker is subject to nearly all of them at once.

Forager equality (baseline)

- Surplus + storage (wealth becomes concentrated & defensible)
- Sedentism ends exit (can't walk away anymore)
- Leveling defeated (sharing dies, the boaster wins)
- Control of subsistence (whoever holds the food holds the people)
- Inheritance (a one-time gain becomes a dynasty)
- Debt (bondage the victim consents to)
- The ledger (power remembers what you owe, forever)
- Sacralization (obedience reframed as cosmic order)
- Dispersed responsibility (the corporation: no one is to blame)
- Coercion masked as freedom (submit, or "leave and go where?")

→ Durable archy (self-reproducing structure)

↻ Counter-current pushes back at every link

(jubilee, revolt, union, abolition)

By the bottom of the chain every original safeguard is gone, which is why the result is *durable* rather than dependent on any single tyrant. The loop at the foot matters as much as the chain: the counter-current never broke it, but it bent it repeatedly — and that perennial pushback is the evidence that none of this was inevitable.

The verdict on inevitability

The strong inevitability thesis — agriculture made hierarchy automatic — fails. Çatalhöyük had every necessary condition and stayed flat for a millennium (Era 2); the Indus civilization built cities without god-kings (Era 3); Neolithic communities built inequality and then dismantled it; the deep Palaeolithic may have moved consciously between political modes (Era 1). The ratchet did not lock everywhere it could have, and it sometimes ran backwards. Hierarchy is a *recurrent human possibility*, reached by genuinely different roads (chattel slavery in Rome, bureaucratic duty in Han China, caste in India), not a law of nature.

But the weak version holds, and it is sobering. The Neolithic and after did supply *necessary conditions* — storable surplus, heritable estates, reduced exit, the death of demand-sharing — that made durable archy *available* as it had never been, and that progressively *defeated the leveling mechanisms* one by one. The dice were loaded even though they were not thrown for us. The honest verdict is therefore neither "always coming" nor "single wrong turn," but: *humans build hierarchy and dismantle it repeatedly, and it locks in under identifiable conditions — concentrated storable defensible resources, plus the loss of exit — which the modern world has supplied at ever greater scale*. Inequality is neither natural nor accidental; it is *conditional and constructed*, which means it is also, in principle, *reversible* — a fact the next thread makes concrete.

The through-line: the counter-current never died

The single most important thread running the length of this document is that the leveling impulse of Era 1 was *never extinguished*. It was defeated, masked, sacralized away, outscaled — but it surfaced in every era, and over time it learned to win.

It runs from the foragers who ridiculed the boaster and executed the tyrant (Era 1); through the megalithic communal tombs refusing the individuating monument (Era 2); through the jubilee that periodically wiped the slate clean (Era 3); through the Stoic insistence on inner freedom and the revolt of Spartacus (Era 4); through the peasant risings asking "when Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?" (Era 5); through the abolition movement and the Haitian

Revolution that first crossed the *abolition horizon* — the genuinely new idea that an entire ancient form of domination could be *ended*, not merely relieved or fled (Era 6); through the unions, the strike, the franchise, the great emancipations, and the welfare state that achieved the most thorough taming of archy the large-scale world has seen (Era 7); and into the present, where gig workers reinvent collective resistance against management-by-algorithm (Era 8).

This counter-current matters for the deepest reason of all: it is the empirical proof that archy is not destiny. The same species that built the granary's coercion, the god-king's charter, the slave ship, and the surveillance platform also built the reverse dominance hierarchy, the jubilee, the abolition movement, the union, and the universal franchise. We are not by nature levelers or by nature climbers. We are the animal that does both, and which one prevails is decided — as it was decided around every forager campfire that mocked a man for boasting about his kill — by institutions, conditions, and the choices of the many about how much power they will allow the few. The history of archy is, read correctly, also the history of its perennial contestation. The story is not over, and on the evidence of thirty thousand years, it was never going to be.

Part II — Power, Wealth, and Inequality Across the Eras

The quantities. Part I named the mechanisms; this part measures their result — group sizes, what people kept versus surrendered, the claim to rule, and the inequality that followed, with every number marked by its certainty.

How to read this document, and how much to trust the numbers

Part I traced the *mechanisms* by which the power of one human over another was built and dismantled across eight eras. This part does something narrower and more concrete: it asks, for each of those same eras, **how big were the groups, how were they structured, what did ordinary people contribute and keep, how much did the top accumulate, who pushed back, and on what grounds did rulers claim the right to rule**. Where a number exists, it appears. Where a number is an estimate, it is marked as such. Where there is no honest number, the text says so rather than inventing one.

A word on the central measure. Most quantified inequality here uses the **Gini coefficient**, a scale from 0 (everyone holds exactly the same) to 1 (one household holds everything). For ancient societies with no tax records, archaeologists cannot measure income, so they use a clever proxy: the variation in **house sizes** within a settlement. If every dwelling is nearly the same size, the Gini is low; if a few mansions tower over many hovels, it is high. The single most

useful body of work here is Kohler, Smith, and colleagues' 2017 study in *Nature*, which calculated house-size Ginis for 63 archaeological sites across four continents and 11,000 years. Its headline series — which recurs throughout this document — runs roughly as follows: hunter-gatherers a median Gini of about 0.17, small-scale horticulturalists about 0.27, larger agricultural societies about 0.35, and the most unequal ancient Old World societies reaching about 0.59, against a modern United States figure variously pegged at 0.80 to 0.85. Keep that arc in mind; it is the quantitative spine of everything below.

Three honesty caveats apply throughout. First, **certainty degrades as we go back**. A Roman census figure and a modern Gini are real measurements; a Palaeolithic "group size" is an inference from living foragers and a handful of sites. Each section flags its confidence. Second, **house-size Gini is a proxy, not the thing itself** — it captures durable wealth, not income, slaves, or political power, and it can understate inequality in societies where the elite's advantage lay in people owned or offices held rather than floor space. Third, **every era contained enormous internal variation**; the figures are central tendencies, not universal laws, and the counter-cases (a flat city here, a steep chieftdom there) matter as much as the averages.

A note on certainty labels used below:

- **[measured]** — based on real records or direct archaeological measurement; the most reliable.
 - **[estimated]** — a scholarly reconstruction or model, defensible but with real error bars.
 - **[inferred]** — extrapolated from analogy (e.g. living foragers) or indirect evidence; treat as a reasoned guess.
 - **[contested]** — actively disputed among specialists; the figure is one position among several.
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Era 1 — Forager egalitarianism

Deep prehistory – c. 12,000 BCE

Group size. The basic foraging unit, the band or "overnight camp," averaged roughly **25 people**, commonly ranging from about 25 to 50 [inferred, from living hunter-gatherers]. Bands were nested in larger but more diffuse layers: a community or "cultural lineage" of perhaps **100–230 people** (the band-of-bands that met, intermarried, and shared a dialect), and a tribe or regional pool of perhaps **500–2,500** who shared a language and met only periodically [inferred]. The often-cited "Dunbar's number" of ~150 names the community layer, not the camp; recent fieldwork finds local bands averaging closer to 30, with wide variation (one survey found group sizes from 42 to over 440), so the round numbers should be held loosely [contested]. The

decisive structural fact is that the unit you lived with day to day was small enough that everyone knew everyone, and membership was *fluid* — you could leave one band and join another.

Structure and roles. Essentially flat. Division of labor ran mainly by age and sex (a generalization with many exceptions), not by class. Influence accrued to skilled hunters, wise elders, gifted mediators and storytellers, but it was **non-coercive and non-heritable** — a respected hunter's son inherited no office. There were no full-time specialists, no standing authority, no one who did not also forage.

Contributed, shared, kept, accumulated. Almost everything acquired was *shared*, especially large game, through obligatory distribution and "demand sharing" (anyone may ask, refusal is shameful). What people *kept* was personal: tools, ornaments, clothing — what one could carry. What anyone *accumulated* was close to nil, because mobility punishes hoarding and the leveling ethic forbids it. This is why the forager Gini sits near the floor of the human range: **a median of about 0.17** [measured, for sampled sites], the lowest of any society type in the Kohler series. The residual 0.17 is real but reflects differences in portable goods and skill, not the institutional, heritable wealth gap of later eras.

Counter-currents (here, the *main current*). This is the one era where leveling is not the counter-current but the dominant force. The toolkit — ridicule of boasters, "insulting the meat," demand sharing, the freedom to walk away, and in the extreme the ostracism or killing of a would-be tyrant — constitutes Christopher Boehm's **reverse dominance hierarchy**: the many actively holding down any one who tries to rise. Archy is the deviation that has to fight *this*.

Claim to rule. None, in the institutional sense. To the extent anyone "led," the claim was **competence and consent in the moment** — people followed a good hunter on a hunt and a good mediator in a dispute, and stopped following when the task ended. There was no standing claim, no office, no inheritance, no appeal to gods or birth.

Era 2 — The Neolithic threshold

c. 12,000 – 4,000 BCE

Group size. Settlement allowed unprecedented aggregation. Early villages ran from dozens to a few hundred; the great proto-town of **Çatalhöyük held on the order of 3,500–8,000 people** at its peak [estimated], an almost unimaginable crowd by forager standards, packed into clustered mudbrick houses. The pre-agricultural ceremonial site of Göbekli Tepe drew labor from a wide region for monumental building [estimated]. The ceiling on group size was rising by one to two orders of magnitude.

Structure and roles. Contested and *variable* — which is the era's whole lesson. Some communities developed emergent rank; others, strikingly, did not. Çatalhöyük shows near-uniform houses with no palace, no elite quarter, and no rich-versus-poor housing for roughly a thousand years, implying a powerful ideology of household equivalence [measured, from architecture; interpretation contested]. Specialization (potters, weavers, builders) was emerging but had not yet hardened into class.

Contributed, shared, kept, accumulated. The novelty is the **storable, heritable surplus**: grain in the granary, animals in the herd, a cleared field passing to one's children. For the first time, what a household *kept and accumulated* could exceed what it immediately consumed and could be *transmitted across generations*. Sharing did not vanish, but demand-sharing could not survive a harvest one household grew and another did not. Quantitatively, the move off the forager floor is clear: small-scale horticulturalists show a **median Gini of about 0.27**, and larger agricultural communities about **0.35** [measured, for sampled sites] — a near-doubling from the forager 0.17. But the variance is the point: Çatalhöyük and the Carpathian Basin communities stayed remarkably flat for millennia (one *Science Advances* study found Carpathian societies resisting inequality for ~5,000 years) [measured], proving the higher median was a tendency, not a law.

Counter-currents. Now genuinely a *counter*-current, and visibly active. The great communal **megalithic tombs** — long barrows and passage graves pooling many anonymous bodies — assert the collective over any individual, the leveling ethos rendered in stone. Some communities built emergent hierarchy and then *dismantled* it, the ratchet running backwards. The forager leveling instinct had not died; it was fighting on harder terrain.

Claim to rule. Still thin and emergent. Where leaders arose, the claim rested on the **"big man" / aggrandizer pathway**: generosity that creates debt. A lavish feast, funded from surplus, put guests under an obligation discharged through loyalty and labor — prestige convertible, for the first time, into a following. The claim was not yet *birth* or *gods* but *beneficence weaponized*: I feed you, therefore you owe me.

Era 3 — The first states and the god-kings

c. 4,000 – 800 BCE

Group size. The state shatters the old ceilings. Early Uruk may have held **25,000–50,000 people**; by the later third and second millennia some Mesopotamian and Egyptian cities and their hinterlands governed **hundreds of thousands**, and the largest territorial states approached or exceeded a million subjects [estimated]. The face-to-face band of 25 is now a rounding error inside a polity of a million strangers — and ruling strangers who cannot all know each other is precisely the problem the new tools solve.

Structure and roles. The first true **class society** with full-time specialists who do not farm: a ruler and royal household; a priesthood managing the temple estates; scribes and bureaucrats running the ledgers; soldiers; artisans; a mass of peasant cultivators; and, at the bottom, debt-bondsmen and slaves. The defining innovation is the *standing office* that outlives its holder — power is now institutional, not merely personal.

Contributed, shared, kept, accumulated. Peasants contributed a share of harvest as **tax/tribute** and a season of **corvée** (compulsory labor on canals, walls, temples, tombs). The temple-state was the great accumulator: it owned much of the land, ran the central granary, employed and rationed labor. Private accumulation now ran steeply upward through office, land, and above all **debt** — a bad harvest forced a loan at savage interest, default forfeited oxen, then land, then children, then the debtor himself. The wealth gap widens sharply: ancient Old World Ginis climb toward their eventual peak of about **0.59** in the most stratified societies [estimated/measured], though early-state figures sit somewhere between the agricultural 0.35 and that ceiling. House-size Gini almost certainly *understates* real inequality here, because the pharaoh's or king's advantage lay in owning people and commanding the state, not merely in floor area.

Counter-currents. The signature device is the **debt jubilee**: the Mesopotamian "clean slate" (*andurarum*) and the biblical Jubilee, in which non-commercial debts were cancelled, debt-slaves freed, and forfeited land restored — often proclaimed by a new king. Crucially this was *managed relief from above*, designed to stop debt from hollowing out the taxpaying, soldiering population, not a popular liberation. The leveling impulse survives, but now as royal policy venting the system's worst pressure rather than as the band restraining a boaster. The era's deepest counter-evidence is structural: the **Indus Valley civilization** ran large planned cities for centuries with no convincing palaces, royal tombs, or god-king iconography [measured/contested] — complexity without the king.

Claim to rule. The great invention: **divinity**. The Egyptian pharaoh was a god, the living Horus, guarantor of *ma'at* (cosmic order); the Mesopotamian king ruled as the god's chosen steward, the city literally owned by its deity. To disobey was not crime but sacrilege — the unmaking of the world. China's later **Mandate of Heaven** added a revolutionary clause: Heaven grants rule to the just and *withdraws* it from the cruel, making rule conditional and supplying a ready justification for overthrowing a tyrant. The claim moves from "I feed you" (Era 2) to "the cosmos commands you obey me."

Era 4 — Classical empires and slavery

c. 800 BCE – 500 CE

Group size. Imperial scale. The Roman Empire at its height governed perhaps **60–70 million people** [estimated]; Han China, contemporaneously, recorded a census of roughly **57–60 million** [measured, Han census of 2 CE — remarkably, an actual head-count]. The city of Rome itself approached **one million** inhabitants [estimated]. Politics now spanned continents and dozens of subject peoples.

Structure and roles. Steep, legally codified, and — crucially — **graded rather than binary**. Rome ran a ladder of statuses: senators and equestrians at the top, then citizens, Latins, freedmen, provincial subjects, and at the base a vast enslaved population. Athens drew a hard line between citizen, metic (resident foreigner), and slave. Han China governed through a *bureaucracy* of text-trained officials rather than a slave/free divide, legitimated by reciprocal-but-unequal Confucian duties. Same outcome — the few over the many at imperial scale — by different roads.

Contributed, shared, kept, accumulated. This is the era of **mass chattel slavery as the economic foundation**. Estimates suggest the enslaved were on the order of **a third of the population of Roman Italy and perhaps 10–15% of the empire overall** [estimated/contested], legally things — bought, sold, worked in mines and on the great estates (*latifundia*). Free citizens contributed taxes and military service; the enslaved contributed everything and kept nothing, not even themselves. Wealth concentrated enormously: a Roman senator's fortune could exceed that of tens of thousands of ordinary households, and the abstract, accumulable power of **coined money** (new in this era) let wealth pile up without limit, tied to no rotting granary. The classical Gini, where measurable, sits high in the ancient range, near the ~0.59 ceiling in the most stratified cores [estimated].

Counter-currents. Weak, and tellingly so. Slave revolts (Spartacus, 73–71 BCE) sought escape, not abolition — **the very idea of abolishing slavery did not yet exist** [the most important fact in this row]. The Stoics taught inner freedom and a brotherhood of rational beings (Epictetus, himself once enslaved, held that the master could chain the body but never the will), yet preached endurance, not overthrow. The leveling impulse had been not merely defeated but *philosophized out of view*: Aristotle's doctrine of the "natural slave" recast subordination as the victim's own inborn nature.

Claim to rule. Plural. In the West, increasingly **law, citizenship, and office** — the emperor as supreme magistrate and, later, as a divine or quasi-divine figure (the imperial cult). In Han China, the **Mandate of Heaven** plus the claim of *meritorious, text-trained competence* — rule justified by learning and the cultivation of virtue. Persia's "king of kings" claimed to rule a

tolerated mosaic of peoples by divine favor (Ahura Mazda). The common thread: the claim now rests on *institutions* — law, cosmic mandate, office — that outlive any individual ruler.

Era 5 — Feudal and tributary orders

c. 500 – 1450

Group size. Political *fragmentation* in the European west: after Rome's western collapse, effective power localized to the manor, the lordship, the small kingdom — units of hundreds to a few thousand on a given estate, even as nominal kingdoms and the great Asian empires remained large. The relevant lived unit shrank back toward the village of a few hundred [estimated]. Elsewhere, large centralized states persisted (Tang and Song China governed tens of millions; the Islamic caliphates spanned continents) [measured/estimated], so "feudal" describes a *type of relation*, not a global scale.

Structure and roles. The defining fact across civilizations is **labor bound to land**. The European serf was *adscriptus glebae* — written into the soil, transferred with the land, owing labor-days and dues, unable to leave without permission, yet not a saleable chattel. Parallel systems: Japanese *daimyō* lords and *samurai* over land-bound peasants; the Islamic *iqṭāʿ* (revocable revenue-grants) and *mamlūk* military slavery (slaves who could rise to rule); and India's **caste** system, the most thoroughly *sacralized* hierarchy in human history, fixing rank at birth by religious doctrine of purity, *dharma*, and rebirth.

Contributed, shared, kept, accumulated. Peasants contributed **rent, tithe, dues, and labor** upward to a non-producing elite of warriors and clergy — the tributary mode. A common rough figure is that the peasant surrendered something like **a quarter to a half of output** (the church tithe alone claimed a notional tenth) [estimated, highly variable]. What the peasant *kept* was subsistence plus customary use-rights to common land and the lord's protection; what he *accumulated* was little, since dues skimmed the surplus. The Church and the nobility were the great accumulators of land. Wealth inequality stayed high but, in the European west, somewhat *below* the most extreme ancient peaks during the early medieval centuries, before climbing again — the Old World Gini trend resumes its rise toward ~0.59 and beyond as commerce revives [estimated].

Counter-currents. Vigorous and recurrent. **Peasant revolts** punctuate the era — the English Rising of 1381, the German Peasants' War of 1525, French *jacqueries*, China's Red Turban risings — often explicitly egalitarian. The radical English question "*When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?*" invokes an original equality and brands lords as usurpers. And a demographic accident, the **Black Death** (1347–51), killed perhaps a third to half of Europe and, by making labor scarce, handed surviving peasants real bargaining power: wages rose, dues fell, and serfdom withered across the western half of the continent [measured] —

though in Eastern Europe lords tightened it (the "second serfdom"), a warning against assuming any single direction.

Claim to rule. Divine right and sacred function. The monarch answerable to God alone (the direct heir of the god-king charter). The ideology of the **three orders** — those who pray, those who fight, those who work — cast hierarchy as a divinely ordained division of mutual service. Caste pushed this furthest: rank as cosmic and karmic law, subordination *deserved across lifetimes*. The claim is now *birth plus God*: I rule because I was born to it and Heaven wills it.

Era 6 — Mercantilism, colonialism, and the Atlantic system

c. 1450 – 1800

Group size. Power goes *global* and is exercised at a distance. The relevant unit is no longer the polity but the **empire-plus-trading-network**: a chartered company governing millions of subjects an ocean away. The English East India Company came to rule the Indian subcontinent's tens of millions; the Atlantic system linked European metropolises, African coasts, and American plantations into one extractive web spanning continents [estimated].

Structure and roles. Two novel structures dominate. First, the **joint-stock chartered company** — an immortal, impersonal accumulator separating ownership (shareholders) from management (directors) from those who suffer its actions, and granted *sovereign* powers to wage war, coin money, and rule territory. Second, **racialized chattel slavery**: a caste of the permanently, heritably enslaved, justified by the newly invented ideology of *race*. Society is now stratified across continents and color lines simultaneously.

Contributed, shared, kept, accumulated. The enslaved contributed their lives and kept nothing — the **transatlantic trade forcibly shipped an estimated 12.5 million Africans**, with perhaps **1.5–2 million dying in the Middle Passage** [estimated, from the Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database — one of the better-quantified atrocities in history]. Their uncompensated labor grew the sugar, tobacco, and cotton that built metropolitan wealth. The colony, like the medieval peasant, existed to pump surplus to the center: silver from Potosí (mined under the coerced *mita* draft) flowed to Spain and on to China. Accumulation concentrated in merchant elites, planters, and shareholders; the era opens the long climb of Old World inequality toward and past its ancient ceiling as global extraction feeds European capital [estimated].

Counter-currents. Here the counter-current does something **genuinely new — it crosses the abolition horizon**. For the first time in history a mass movement declared an ancient form of bondage an abomination to be *ended everywhere*: Quakers, formerly enslaved activists like Olaudah Equiano, and Enlightenment natural-rights arguments. And the enslaved proved it could be won by force: the **Haitian Revolution (1791–1804)** — the only slave revolt in history to

found a free state — defeated the armies of France, Spain, and Britain. After five thousand years of relief (the jubilee) and escape (Spartacus), the idea that a whole category of domination could be *abolished* finally existed.

Claim to rule. Transitional and increasingly *commercial*. Older divine-right claims persisted, but alongside them came the **charter** — the legal grant of monopoly and sovereignty to a company — and the naked claim of **conquest and racial superiority**: Europeans asserting a right to rule and enslave grounded in an invented hierarchy of human kinds. The claim is sliding from "God and birth" toward "ownership, contract, and race."

Era 7 — Industrial capitalism

c. 1800 – 1970

Group size. The **nation-state** becomes the dominant container, governing tens to hundreds of millions with unprecedented reach — census, passport, compulsory schooling, conscription, police. By the mid-twentieth century the largest states governed hundreds of millions; the planet's population crossed into the billions. The lived economic unit became the **factory and the city** — thousands of strangers coordinated under one roof and one clock.

Structure and roles. The central relation is **wage labor**: workers legally *free* — owning themselves, free to quit and move — but *separated from the means of production* and therefore compelled to sell their labor "or starve." Society sorts into capital (owners of factories, finance, land) and labor (those with only their capacity to work), with a growing salaried middle of managers, clerks, and professionals. **Taylorism** ("scientific management") deskills work into timed fragments, concentrating knowledge and control in management.

Contributed, shared, kept, accumulated. Workers contributed labor for a wage; the gap between the value produced and the wage paid (Marx's surplus value) accumulated as profit to owners. Early industrial inequality was brutal and rose toward the historic highs — and then, remarkably, *fell*. The mid-twentieth-century West saw the "**Great Compression**": through unionization, progressive taxation (top marginal rates reached **70–90%+** in the mid-century US and UK) [measured], and the welfare state, inequality dropped to its lowest modern levels. The US wealth Gini, pegged around **0.80** later in the century [measured], was meaningfully lower at mid-century; income inequality in particular compressed hard. This is the most thorough *taming* of archy the large-scale world has achieved.

Counter-currents. The strongest in the whole history, and partly *victorious*. The **labor movement** turned workers' numbers into organized force — the union and the strike reinventing the forager's collective leveling for industrial conditions — winning the eight-hour day, the weekend, the abolition of child labor, workplace safety, the minimum wage, and the right to

organize. The **franchise** was prised open from propertied men to working men, then (through often-violent suffrage struggle) to women, then to excluded racial groups. The great **emancipations** — completing abolition, the women's movement against the oldest archy of all, and the post-1945 **anti-colonial** movements that dismantled the formal empires of Era 6 — turned the leveling impulse against every inherited hierarchy at once. The horizon that opened with abolition kept widening until, in principle, no inherited domination was beyond question.

Claim to rule. Shifts decisively toward two modern bases. Politically, **popular sovereignty and the nation** — rule justified by representing "the people," legitimated through elections and national identity rather than God or birth (nationalism the heir to the divine charter, binding the individual through belonging). Economically, **property and contract** — the owner's authority over the workplace grounded in ownership and in the worker's "free" agreement to the wage bargain. The claim is now "the people authorize me" and "I own it, and you agreed."

Era 8 — The present

c. 1970 – now

Group size. Effectively **global and networked**. Supply chains, capital flows, and digital platforms operate across the entire species of ~8 billion. A single platform firm can "manage" tens of millions of workers and billions of users at once. The lived unit fractures: simultaneously the whole planet (one integrated economy) and the isolated individual (the gig worker alone with an app).

Structure and roles. The mid-century taming has substantially **unwound**. Unions weakened (often by law and by the offshoring of their industrial base), top tax rates fell, capital was deregulated and freed to move across borders. New structures: the **transnational corporation** (the chartered company's descendant, immortal and accountability-dispersing), the **financial sector** governing the economy through ownership of claims, and **algorithmic management** — software performing the foreman's functions of allocation, surveillance, discipline, and termination, often over workers reclassified as "independent contractors" stripped of the protections Era 7 won.

Contributed, shared, kept, accumulated. Concentration has returned toward pre-compression levels. Current figures: the richest **1% own close to 44%** of global wealth, while the poorest half of humanity holds **just over 0.5%**; the top **10% of earners take more than the other 90% combined**; **billionaire wealth reached ~\$18.3 trillion in 2025, up ~81% since 2020**, even as roughly **one in four people lack regular adequate food** [measured, Oxfam / World Inequality Report 2026]. The modern wealth Gini (~0.80–0.85 in the US) [measured] sits *far above* the ancient Old World ceiling of ~0.59 — by this proxy, contemporary inequality exceeds anything in

the deep past. A genuinely new category of accumulation appears: **data** — human behavior itself captured as raw material, refined into prediction, and concentrated in a handful of firms.

Counter-currents. Active but, so far, not yet matching Era 7's victories. Gig workers develop algorithmic "workaround strategies," external alliances, and new forms of organizing against management-by-code — the union impulse reaching for new tools. Debate over a **debt jubilee** has returned to serious discussion, precisely because the ancient pressure the jubilee was built to relieve has returned without the relief. Movements for tax justice, antitrust, data rights, and a renewed labor militancy represent the same perennial leveling impulse, now facing a depersonalized, globalized, and partly automated adversary.

Claim to rule. Layered and increasingly *contested*. Formal political authority still rests on **popular sovereignty** (elections, representation). But economic power rests on **property, contract, and shareholder value**, and increasingly on the claim of **efficiency, expertise, and meritocracy** — the assertion that those at the top are there because they are most capable or most productive (the modern, market-flavored heir to Aristotle's "natural" hierarchy and India's karmic rank). Oxfam's finding that billionaires are *4,000 times more likely to hold political office than ordinary people* [measured] suggests the two claims — democratic and propertied — are fusing in ways the era has not resolved.

The master table: from door-opening mechanisms to practiced archy

This is the heart of the document. On the **left** sit the mechanisms that *open the door* to power — the devices, identified in Part I, by which the power of one human over another is generated. For each era, each mechanism is rated on a **0–5 scale** for how *active* or *developed* it was (0 = absent, 5 = maximally developed). On the **right** sits the *result*: two summary measures of how much archy was actually practiced — the **wealth Gini** (where known or estimated) and an overall **archy index** (0–5), the degree to which a few held coercive power over the many.

The logic the table makes visible: **archy on the right tracks the sum of the mechanisms on the left**. When the door-openers are weak (Era 1), archy is near zero. As they switch on one by one — surplus, then the end of exit, then debt and the ledger, then sacralization — the archy index climbs. And where the *counter-current* is strong (Era 7), it visibly pulls the realized archy *below* what the raw mechanisms would predict — the one column that pushes the other way.

Mechanism scores are structured judgment, calibrated to Part I [estimated]; Gini figures carry the certainty noted in each era above.

Mechanism activation by era (0 = absent, 5 = maximally developed)

Door-opening mechanism	E1 Forager	E2 Neolithic	E3 First states	E4 Classical	E5 Feudal	E6 Atlantic	E7 Industrial	E8 Present
Surplus & storage	0	3	4	4	4	5	5	5
Loss of exit	0	2	4	4	5	4	3	3
Leveling defeated	0	2	4	5	5	5	3	4
Control of subsistence	0	3	5	5	5	5	4	4
Inheritance of position	0	2	4	4	5	4	3	3
Debt	0	1	4	4	4	4	4	5
The ledger (legibility)	0	0	4	4	3	4	5	5
Sacralization / naturalization	0	1	5	4	5	4	2	2
Dispersed responsibility	0	0	1	2	2	4	4	5

Door-opening mechanism	E1 Forager	E2 Neolithic	E3 First states	E4 Classical	E5 Feudal	E6 Atlantic	E7 Industrial	E8 Present
Coercion masked as free exchange	0	0	1	2	2	3	5	5
— Counter-current strength —	5	3	2	1	2	3	5	3

The result: practiced archy

Outcome measure	E1	E2	E3	E4	E5	E6	E7	E8
Wealth Gini (measured/estimated)	~0.17	~0.27–0.35	~0.45–0.59	~0.55–0.59	~0.50–0.60	~0.55–0.65	~0.40–0.55	~0.80–0.85
Gini certainty	measured	measured	estimated	estimated	estimated	estimated	measured	measured
Archy index (0–5)	0.3	1.5	4.0	4.3	4.3	4.5	3.0	4.2

Two readings to draw out. First, the **archy index is essentially the mechanism column-sum minus the counter-current** — Era 1's near-zero archy reflects ten dormant mechanisms and a maximal counter-current; Era 4's high archy reflects most mechanisms switched on and the

counter-current at its historical weakest (no concept of abolition yet). Second, **Era 7 is the anomaly that proves the counter-current is real**: its door-opening mechanisms are nearly as developed as Era 8's, yet its realized archy and Gini are markedly *lower*, because the counter-current (unions, franchise, welfare state, emancipations) was at a historic peak and actively dragged the outcome down. Era 8 then shows what happens when the mechanisms stay maxed but the counter-current retreats: archy and Gini climb back up, the Gini past anything in the measured past.

Reading the whole arc

Set the eight eras side by side and three patterns emerge from the numbers.

The long climb, and its one great interruption. The wealth Gini rises from the forager floor of ~0.17 through the agricultural 0.27–0.35 to the ancient ceiling of ~0.59, holds roughly there across the classical, feudal, and Atlantic eras, then does something unprecedented in Era 7: it *falls*. The mid-twentieth-century compression — driven by the strongest counter-current in history — is the single sustained reversal of the upward trend across 12,000 years. Then Era 8 resumes the climb and overshoots everything before it, reaching ~0.80–0.85, a level of measured wealth concentration that exceeds the steepest god-king or slave society we can quantify. By this proxy, the present is not a return to the ancient norm but an excursion beyond it.

Group size and archy rose together — until they didn't. For most of the arc, bigger groups meant steeper hierarchy: the band of 25 was nearly flat, the city of 50,000 had god-kings, the empire of 60 million had mass slavery. Scale and stratification climbed in tandem because the tools that made large groups governable (the ledger, sacralization, the standing office) were also tools of domination. Era 7 broke even this coupling: the largest, most legible states ever built also achieved the most equality, because the same scale that empowered the state also concentrated workers who could organize. Scale is not destiny; what matters is whether the scale-tools serve extraction or get captured by the counter-current.

The claim to rule keeps migrating, but never disappears. It runs from *competence-in-the-moment* (E1) to *beneficence weaponized* (E2) to *divinity* (E3) to *law and cosmic mandate* (E4) to *birth-plus-God* (E5) to *charter, conquest, and race* (E6) to *popular sovereignty and property* (E7) to *democracy fused with property, expertise, and merit* (E8). Each new claim tends to *absorb* rather than replace its predecessors — the present still contains traces of all of them. And every claim answers the same chronic problem the foragers' reverse dominance hierarchy first posed: how can the few justify their power to the many who outnumber them? That the question must keep being answered, in era after era, is itself the evidence that the many never fully stopped asking it.

The master table makes the underlying mechanism vivid: archy on the right is the door-opening mechanisms on the left, minus whatever the counter-current can claw back. Era 1 had ten dormant doors and a maximal counter-current, so archy was near zero. Era 4 had most doors open and the counter-current at its weakest — abolition was not yet even thinkable — so archy peaked. Era 7 had the doors nearly as open as today's, yet pulled its realized archy *down* through unions, the vote, and the welfare state. Era 8 left the doors open and let the counter-current slip, and the Gini climbed past every measured precedent. The doors, once built, are rarely dismantled. What changes — what has always changed — is how hard the many push back against them.

Part III — The Cast and the Machine

The roles and the administrative state. Parts I and II described how power works and how much it concentrated; this part supplies fixed functional categories — six recurring roles — for comparing eras directly, and tracks the machine those roles operate.

Why fixed roles, and which six

Parts I and II tracked *mechanisms* (how power is generated) and *quantities* (how much inequality resulted). This part asks a different question: **who, functionally, was doing what — and can we name those functions in a way that lets us set a Sumerian temple scribe beside a modern compliance officer and see that they are doing the same job?**

The trick is to categorize by *function*, not by local status-label. "Noble," "citizen," "freeman," "shareholder" are era-specific words that don't travel. But the *functions* a stratified society needs filled are remarkably stable. Six of them recur in every era from the first states onward, and tracking who fills each one — and how the slots merge, split, and change hands — is the clearest way to compare societies that otherwise share no vocabulary.

The six roles:

Owners — those who hold the era's primary store of value and draw income from owning it rather than working it. What they own changes (herds, land, slaves, factories, financial claims, data), but the relation is constant: wealth that generates more wealth, transmissible to heirs. This is the apex role; in most eras it overlaps heavily with the next two.

Organizers — those who coordinate production and administration: who plans, allocates, schedules, keeps the books, runs the logistics. The vizier, the steward, the bureaucrat, the

manager, the platform's algorithm. They do not necessarily own; they make the system *run*. This is the role that grows fastest over time and becomes, in the modern era, almost the whole story.

Enforcers — those who supply coercion: soldiers, knights, police, overseers, security. They convert the threat of violence into compliance. Their loyalty is the hinge of every regime, which is why so much of the surplus goes to keeping them fed and loyal, and why they so often become Owners themselves (the warrior aristocracy).

Legitimizers — those whose function is to make the arrangement *feel* natural, just, or inevitable: priests, scribes, court intellectuals, jurists, and in the modern era the press, the academy, the credentialing and ratings bodies, the PR and advertising apparatus. They produce the stories — divine right, natural slavery, karma, meritocracy — that persuade the many to accept rule by the few. This is the cheapest and most powerful technology of control, because a belief internalized needs no soldier behind it.

Producers — those who do the actual work that generates the surplus: farmers, artisans, laborers, wage workers. They are the broad base. They contribute the most and keep the least relative to their contribution. In a flat society they are *everyone*; in a steep one they are the majority who support all the roles above.

Dependents — those with no recognized economic agency of their own, whose access to subsistence runs *through* someone else: the enslaved, the bonded, the destitute, the wholly excluded. They are distinct from Producers in that Producers have at least nominal standing (a citizen-farmer, a wage worker who can quit); Dependents have little or none. The line between Producer and Dependent is one of the most revealing things to watch, because eras differ sharply in how porous it is and how many people sit below it.

Two notes on using the scheme. First, **one person often fills several roles at once** — a feudal lord is Owner, Enforcer, and Organizer of his manor simultaneously; a forager is, briefly and partially, all six and none. The interesting comparative fact is precisely *how bundled or unbundled* the roles are in a given era: archy tends to *bundle* roles at the top (the god-king is Owner + Enforcer + Legitimater fused) and *specialize* them as societies grow more complex. Second, **the roles are functional slots, not moral judgments** — "Legitimater" describes a job, and the same job can be filled by a court flatterer or an honest judge.

The cast, era by era

Era 1 — Forager egalitarianism

The roles barely exist as distinct slots, which is the whole point. Everyone is a **Producer**; everyone shares in what is produced. **Ownership** beyond portable personal goods does not

exist. **Organizing** is ad hoc and consensual — whoever knows the territory leads the hunt, then stops leading. **Enforcement** is collective and turned *upward*: the band as a whole coerces any would-be dominator (the reverse dominance hierarchy), so the enforcement function exists but points the opposite way from every later era. **Legitimation** is the egalitarian ethic itself — the stories told are leveling stories, mocking the boaster, not justifying a ruler. **Dependents** in the later sense are nearly absent; the old, the young, and the sick are supported by the sharing economy as members, not as a separate underclass. The defining feature: the roles are *unbundled and rotating*, held briefly and by consent, never accumulating in one person.

Era 2 — The Neolithic threshold

The slots begin to separate. Most people remain **Producers** (now farmers and herders). The novel figure is the emergent **Owner-Organizer**: the aggrandizer or "big man" who controls a surplus, throws the debt-creating feast, and begins to coordinate others' labor — Owner and Organizer fused in one ambitious household, but not yet hereditary or backed by force.

Enforcement is still mostly communal; there is no standing warrior class yet. **Legitimation** is thin and contested — the communal tombs assert the collective *against* the aggrandizer, so the Legitimator function is still partly working for equality. **Dependents** appear at the margins (the first debt-bondsmen, the first captives) but are not yet a structural class. This is the era of *role-separation beginning but not locking*: at Çatalhöyük the slots stayed fused-and-flat for a millennium; elsewhere they pulled apart.

Era 3 — The first states and the god-kings

All six roles now exist as distinct, full-time, mostly hereditary slots — this is what "the state" means. At the apex, the **god-king fuses Owner + chief Enforcer + chief Legitimator**: he owns (or the god he embodies owns) the land, commands the army, and *is* the cosmic justification. Below him the roles specialize sharply. **Organizers** become a true profession for the first time: the scribe-bureaucrats who invented writing to keep the ledgers, the viziers and overseers who ran the temple estates. **Enforcers** are a standing soldiery. **Legitimators** are a powerful, literate priesthood — and crucially, in this era Organizer and Legitimator overlap heavily, because the temple is simultaneously the account-house and the house of the god, so the man keeping the grain ledger is also a priest. **Producers** are the peasant mass.

Dependents are now a large structural class: debt-bondsmen and slaves. The signature of the era is *maximum bundling at the very top* (the god-king as everything) over *newly specialized roles* below.

Era 4 — Classical empires and slavery

The apex *unbundles* somewhat — a Roman emperor is supreme but not literally a god in the Egyptian sense (the imperial cult is a claim, not a metaphysics), and Han China deliberately separates the functions. The most important development is the professionalization and partial separation of **Organizers** from **Owners**. In Rome the senatorial Owners still dominated, but a vast administrative apparatus of equestrian officials, tax-farmers, and freedman-bureaucrats ran the machine. In Han China the separation went furthest: the **Organizers became a distinct**,

text-trained scholar-official class selected partly on merit, ideally *not* the same people as the great landowning Owners — the first serious attempt to make the Organizer role independent of the Owner role. **Enforcers** (the legions) became so central that they repeatedly made and unmade emperors — the enforcement role capturing the apex. **Legitimizers** split into a religious wing (priests, the imperial cult) and a secular wing (jurists, philosophers, the rhetoricians who justified the order in law and reason — Aristotle's natural-slavery doctrine is Legitimater work). **Producers** were free peasants and artisans; **Dependents** were the enormous enslaved population, now the economic foundation rather than a marginal class. The signature: *the Organizer role professionalizes and, in the East, begins to detach from ownership.*

Era 5 — Feudal and tributary orders

After Rome's western collapse, the roles *re-bundle* violently in the figure of the lord. The European feudal lord is simultaneously **Owner** (of the manor), **Enforcer** (the armed knight), and **Organizer** (of the estate's production and justice) — three roles fused in one person at the local level, which is exactly what "feudalism" is: the collapse of the specialized state back into personal, bundled, land-based power. The **Legitimater** role, by contrast, *specializes and centralizes* in the Church — a continent-spanning institution that monopolized the justifying stories (divine right, the three orders) and literacy itself, and was also a massive **Owner** in its own right. **Producers** are the serfs, bound to the land. **Dependents** shade into the serfs below them and the household slaves where they persisted. Elsewhere the bundling differs instructively: the Islamic world deliberately *unbundled* by using revocable iqṭāʿ grants and slave-soldiers (mamluks) to *prevent* Enforcers from becoming hereditary Owners; China kept its scholar-official Organizers separate from the military Enforcers on purpose. The signature: *in the European core, the state dissolves and the top three roles re-fuse in the local lord, while the Legitimater role globalizes in the Church.*

Era 6 — Mercantilism, colonialism, and the Atlantic system

A genuinely new kind of Owner-Organizer appears: the **joint-stock company**, which fuses Owner (the shareholders) and Organizer (the directors and factors) into a single immortal legal person — and is then granted **Enforcer** powers (its own armies and fleets) and quasi-sovereign authority. For the first time the Owner-Organizer-Enforcer bundle is held not by a person but by an *abstraction*, which is why responsibility disperses. The state begins to grow again behind it (the absolutist monarchies, the chartered grants), so there are now *two* overlapping power structures: the dynastic state and the corporate one, often fused. **Legitimizers** add a dark new product: the ideology of **race**, manufactured to justify the largest Dependent class in history — the racialized enslaved, now defined as a permanent, heritable, sub-human category. **Producers** in the metropole; **Dependents** on the plantation, with the line between them hardened into color and made uncrossable. The signature: *the Owner-Organizer-Enforcer bundle migrates from persons to the corporation, and the Dependent class is racialized and maximized.*

Era 7 — Industrial capitalism

The roles reach their most *specialized and separated* configuration in history — and this separation is the era's central drama. **Ownership** (capital) and **Organization** (management) formally split: the rise of the salaried professional manager who runs a firm he does not own is the defining structural novelty, the famous "separation of ownership and control." **Organizers** explode into a vast new salaried middle class — managers, clerks, engineers, administrators — who are neither Owners nor Producers in the old sense, and whose loyalty the system must now buy. **Enforcers** are professionalized and nationalized: the standing police and army belong to the state, not to private Owners (mostly). **Legitimizers** secularize and proliferate: the press, the universities, the advertising industry, the economics profession, nationalism itself — the justifying stories now run through mass media and credentials rather than the pulpit. **Producers** are the industrial working class, now legally *free* (self-owning, able to quit) but separated from the means of production. **Dependents** shrink as a legal category (chattel slavery abolished, serfdom gone) even as a new precarious underclass persists. The signature: *Owner and Organizer split, the Organizer class balloons, and the Producer becomes legally free — the most unbundled the roles ever get.* And it is precisely in this maximally specialized era that the counter-current was strongest, because a Producer class concentrated in factories and conscious of itself as a class could organize.

Era 8 — The present

The configuration is paradoxical: roles are simultaneously *more separated* (a global supply chain disperses them across continents and legal entities) and *re-fusing at the top* in new ways. **Ownership** re-concentrates dramatically (the return of inherited wealth and the billionaire class) and increasingly *re-merges with Organization* through founder-owners and controlling shareholders who both own and run the largest firms — a partial reversal of Era 7's separation. The most novel development is that the **Organizer role is migrating from humans into algorithms**: the platform's software now performs allocation, scheduling, surveillance, and discipline — the steward's and foreman's job, automated and depersonalized. **Enforcement** remains mostly with the state, but private security, and the "soft enforcement" of credit scores, platform deactivation, and exclusion from digital infrastructure, supplement it. **Legitimizers** are the media conglomerates (increasingly owned *by* the apex Owners — note the billionaire purchases of major newspapers), the ratings agencies, the credentialing universities, and the meritocratic ideology that says the top deserves its position by talent. **Producers** are the global workforce, including the gig worker reclassified out of employee protections. **Dependents** include the informally employed, the platform-precarious, and — a genuinely new category — *everyone as a data-subject*, whose behavioral exhaust is extracted as raw material regardless of their consent or economic role. The signature: *Owner and Organizer re-fuse at the top, the Organizer role automates, and a new universal Dependency (data-subjecthood) overlays the old economic ones.*

The machine: the administrative state, and how private power plugs into it

The roles above describe *who does what*. This section tracks a single institution through the eras — **the administrative state**, the standing apparatus of officials, records, and rules that can reach into ordinary life to count, tax, conscript, register, and command — and asks two linked questions at each step. First, **how strong is the machine itself**: how deeply can it actually reach into the average person's life? Second, **how does individual power tap into it**: when a private person wants to get rich or stay on top, do they do it by *capturing* the state, by *being* the state, or by operating *outside* it?

The two questions matter together because the relationship between private wealth and public administration is the master-variable of archy in the large-scale eras. A strong state can be a leveler (it can tax the rich and protect the weak) or the ultimate tool of extraction (it can tax the weak for the rich) — what determines which is *who has captured the machine*.

The state's reach, era by era

Era 1 — Forager: no machine at all. There is no administrative apparatus, no standing office, no records. "Reach into your life" is meaningless because there is nothing to do the reaching. Individual power cannot tap into state power because there is no state; it can only tap into persuasion and prestige, both of which the leveling mechanisms actively cap. *State strength: zero. Private access route: none — power is personal and capped.*

Era 2 — Neolithic: proto-administration. The first storage facilities, the first reckoning of who owes a feast-debt, the first ceremonial coordination of labor (Göbekli Tepe) are the embryo of administration, but there is still no standing apparatus that can compel a stranger. The aggrandizer's power is personal and local — it taps into *obligation and surplus*, not into any machine. *State strength: minimal, embryonic. Private access route: control of surplus and the debt of the feast.*

Era 3 — First states: the machine is born, and it is owned at the top. This is the decisive invention. Writing-as-accountancy, the temple-granary, taxation, the corvée, and the standing bureaucracy together create, for the first time, an apparatus that can reach a peasant the king will never meet and extract grain and labor from him. Its reach is real but *shallow and patchy* by modern standards — it can tax the harvest and conscript for the corvée, but it cannot continuously monitor daily life. Critically, the machine and the apex are *fused*: the king (or the temple he fronts) *owns* the administrative state, so private power and state power are the same thing at the top. There is no "capture" because there is no separation to capture across; to be powerful *is* to be the state. Below the apex, the scribe-Organizers tap into state power by *serving* it — the first careers built on administrative office rather than birth or force. *State strength: real but shallow. Private access route: be the apex (fused), or serve as an official.*

Era 4 — Classical: the machine professionalizes and partly detaches. The Roman and especially the Han state developed genuine bureaucratic depth — censuses (the Han counted ~57 million people, an extraordinary administrative feat), standardized law, coinage, tax rolls, a salaried officialdom. The reach is deeper and more *impersonal* than Era 3: it runs on rules and records that outlive any official. Here the relationship between private power and the state becomes a live drama, because the two are no longer simply fused. In Rome, the great Owner-families *captured* the state from within — the Senate was the apex Owners, governing in their own interest, and tax-farming let private contractors (the publicani) turn public revenue collection into private fortune, the purest early example of *plugging private profit directly into the state's extractive plumbing*. In Han China, the deliberate counter-move: an examination-selected official class meant partly to staff the machine with men *not* drawn from the great Owner-families, an early attempt to keep the state from being simply captured by wealth. The Enforcers (the legions) discovered they could capture the apex directly by force. *State strength: deep and impersonal. Private access routes: own the state from within (Senate), farm its revenue (publicani), or seize it by force (legions) — with China pioneering the meritocratic counter.*

Era 5 — Feudal: the machine shatters and privatizes. The western European story is, uniquely, one of *administrative collapse*. The Roman machine broke, and its functions — taxation, justice, defense — devolved to local lords who ran them as *private* prerogatives. This is the key point for your question: under feudalism, public administration and private power are not merely connected, they are *the same thing at the local level*. The lord's court is his private justice; his dues are his private tax; his men-at-arms are his private army. There is no public machine to capture because the machine *is* private property, fragmented across thousands of lordships. The slow re-building of a public administrative state — royal courts, royal taxation, the first treasuries — across the medieval centuries is precisely the story of pulling these functions *back* out of private hands into a central one. The Church, meanwhile, ran the one genuinely trans-local administrative apparatus (canon law, the only continuous bureaucracy and literate class), making it a quasi-state. Elsewhere the contrast is sharp: the Islamic and Chinese states kept far stronger central administrations, deliberately using revocable grants and examination-officials to stop Enforcers and Owners from privatizing the machine the way European lords did. *State strength: collapsed-and-privatized in the European west, strong-and-central in the Islamic and Chinese worlds. Private access route: in the west, simply own a fragment of the machine outright.*

Era 6 — Atlantic: the dual machine, public and corporate. Two administrative apparatuses now run in parallel and interpenetrate. The absolutist European states rebuilt strong central administrations (standing armies, professional treasuries, the beginnings of statistics — the word "statistics" comes from "state"). Alongside them, the chartered companies built *private* administrative machines of their own — the East India Company governed millions with its own bureaucracy, army, and courts under a grant from the state. The defining relationship of the era is the *charter*: the state delegates its sovereign powers (to tax, rule, wage war, monopolize trade) to a private profit-seeking corporation. This is a new and consequential way for private

power to tap into state power — not by capturing the existing machine but by being granted a *licensed private copy of it*. Individual fortunes were made by securing these charters, monopolies, and offices; the line between public authority and private profit was deliberately blurred. *State strength: rebuilding and centralizing, but deliberately sharing its sovereignty with corporations. Private access route: secure a charter — a licensed private piece of state power.*

Era 7 — Industrial: the machine reaches everyone, and is contested. The modern administrative state achieves, for the first time, *deep and continuous reach into every individual life*. The census, the passport, compulsory schooling, conscription, the income tax, the police force, the registry of births and deaths, the welfare bureaucracy — the state now sees and touches the ordinary person continuously, not just at harvest. James Scott's "legibility" is realized: the state reorganizes society into standardized, countable units it can administer. This is the strongest the machine has ever been at reaching individuals. And here is the era's pivotal fact for your question: *because the machine became so strong, the fight over who controls it became the central political struggle of the age*. The counter-current — unions, the franchise, mass parties — was largely a fight to *capture the administrative state for the Producers*: to use its now-enormous power to tax the Owners, regulate the factories, and build the welfare state. For a few mid-century decades they substantially succeeded, which is why this is the one era where the strong state worked as a *leveler*. Private power tapped into the state through lobbying, campaign finance, and the "revolving door" between corporate and official posts — but it was, for a while, *checked* by the countervailing capture from below. *State strength: maximal reach into individual life. Private access route: lobbying, finance, the revolving door — but contested by mass democratic capture from below.*

Era 8 — Present: the machine is strong, privatized in function, and re-captured from above. The administrative state remains immensely powerful in reach — arguably more so, since digital records, biometric IDs, and data integration let it see individuals with a granularity Scott never imagined. But three things have shifted the private-access story. First, **functional privatization**: many administrative functions (prisons, welfare-eligibility systems, military logistics, even surveillance) are contracted out to private firms, so private profit is again plumbed directly into state operations, echoing the publicani and the chartered companies. Second, **regulatory capture and the financing of politics** have intensified to the point that, by Oxfam's measure, billionaires are about *4,000 times more likely to hold political office than ordinary people*, and a large share of top firms are run or principally owned by billionaires — the apex Owners increasingly *staffing and funding* the machine directly, a partial return to the Roman Senate's fusion of Owner and state. Third, a **second administrative machine has grown up outside the state entirely**: the platform corporations now run private governance systems — terms of service, algorithmic moderation, deactivation, credit and reputation scoring — that regulate hundreds of millions of lives with state-like power but no democratic accountability, the chartered company's private sovereignty reborn in code. The mid-century capture-from-below has weakened as the Producer class fragmented and unions declined. *State strength: maximal and digitally enhanced, but functionally privatized and increasingly captured from above; a parallel private machine governs alongside it.*

The pattern across the whole arc

Read end to end, the administrative state traces an arc that mirrors the inequality curve but illuminates its mechanism. The machine is *born* fused to the apex (E3), *professionalizes and becomes capturable* (E4), *shatters into private hands* in the European feudal exception (E5), *rebuilds while licensing private copies of itself* (E6), *reaches maximal strength and becomes the central prize fought over by mass democracy* (E7), and now stands *strong but functionally privatized and re-captured from above, with a second private machine running alongside it* (E8).

The throughline for individual power is this: **in every era, the surest route to durable private power is to fuse with, capture, or be granted a piece of the administrative machine** — because the machine is what converts a personal advantage into an *institutional, enforceable, heritable* one. The forager could not do this because there was no machine. The god-king was the machine. The Roman senator and the modern billionaire-office-holder *capture* it. The chartered company and the platform firm get *licensed or build a private copy* of it. The one era that broke the pattern — the mid-twentieth century — did so not by weakening the machine but by *democratizing who controlled it*, briefly turning the strongest administrative state in history into an instrument of leveling rather than extraction. That this was possible at all is the strongest evidence in the whole work that the machine is a tool, not a master — and that the decisive question is never how strong the state is, but *whose hands are on it*.

The bundling pattern: how the roles fuse and split

The single most illuminating thing the six-role scheme reveals is not *who* fills each role but *how bundled or separated the roles are* — and this turns out to follow a clear pattern that maps onto the whole history of archy.

The matrix below scores how *concentrated at the apex* each role is, era by era, on a 0–5 scale (0 = diffuse, rotating, or absent; 5 = fused into the ruling apex). Read the rows for how each function travels; read the columns for each era's overall configuration.

Functional role	E1	E2	E3	E4	E5	E6	E7	E8
Owners	·	2	4	3	4	4	3	4
Organizers	·	2	3	3	3	3	3	4
Enforcers	·	1	3	4	4	3	2	2

Functional role	E1	E2	E3	E4	E5	E6	E7	E8
Legitimizers	.	1	4	3	4	3	2	3
Producers	1	2	2	2	2	2	3	2
Dependents	.	1	3	4	3	4	2	3

Three patterns emerge.

Archy bundles at the top; complexity specializes below. The steepest, most concentrated regimes (E3 god-kings, E5 feudal lords) are precisely the ones where Owner, Enforcer, and Legitimater *fuse into one apex figure or institution*. The god-king is all three at once; the feudal lord is Owner-Enforcer-Organizer fused locally. Conversely, the eras of greatest *specialization* — where the roles pull apart into distinct professional classes — are the classical East (E4, where Organizers detached from Owners) and above all industrial capitalism (E7, where Ownership and Organization formally split and the Organizer class ballooned). Bundling and archy rise together; specialization is, paradoxically, often associated with *more* room for the counter-current, because separated roles can be played against each other and a self-conscious Producer class can organize.

The Organizer is the role that only ever grows. Trace its row: absent in E1, emergent in E2, professional in E3, and then a steady, relentless expansion through every later era to its present peak — where it is not only the largest salaried class but is beginning to *automate*, the steward's and foreman's functions migrating into algorithms. If one role defines modernity, it is this one. The administrative state and the corporate bureaucracy are both, fundamentally, vast structures of Organizers.

The apex re-fuses in the present. After E7's historic *separation* of Owner from Organizer, E8 shows them *re-merging* at the top through founder-owners and controlling shareholders who both own and run the largest firms — while the Legitimater function partly re-fuses with Ownership too (the apex Owners buying the media that justifies them). The configuration rhymes with the bundled apex of the ancient god-king, now reassembled out of modern parts: own the firm, run the firm, own the press that explains why you should.

Tying the first three parts together

The first three parts approach the same history from three angles. Part I traced the *mechanisms* — the door-opening devices (surplus, debt, the ledger, sacralization, the loss of exit) by which power over others is generated. Part II *quantified* the result — group sizes, what people kept versus surrendered, and the inequality that followed, era by era. Part III names the *cast and the machine* — the six functional roles that recur across all eras, and the administrative apparatus they operate.

Laid side by side, they converge on one claim. Archy is built when the door-opening mechanisms switch on, *and* the functional roles bundle at the apex, *and* private power captures or fuses with the administrative machine — and it is *unbuilt*, or at least tamed, when the counter-current pries the roles apart, democratizes who holds the machine, and forces the apex to share. The forager had no machine, unbundled roles, and dormant mechanisms, so archy was near zero. The god-king had a new machine he personally owned, a fully bundled apex, and most mechanisms switched on, so archy was near total. The mid-twentieth century had the strongest machine ever built but, for a few decades, *the most democratized control of it* and the most *separated* roles — so the same apparatus that could have been the ultimate engine of extraction became, briefly, the great leveler.

The recurring lesson, across the first three parts, is therefore not that hierarchy is inevitable or that it is escapable, but that it is *conditional* — a function of how the mechanisms, the roles, and the machine happen to be arranged, and of how hard the many are pushing back. The arrangement has been remade many times. It is being remade now.

Part IV — The Excluded, the Cracks, and the Counter-Cases

Cutting across the eras. The earlier parts risked treating the many as undifferentiated, resistance as doomed revolt, and the trajectory as inevitable. This part disaggregates the oppressed, recovers the quiet counter-current, centers the societies that refused kings, and adds the material drivers beneath the social story.

Preface: cutting across the eras

The first three parts marched *through* the eras in sequence. This part cuts *across* them. Each of its five chapters takes a single question and traces it through all eight eras at once, because

these questions — who gets excluded, how people resist when revolt is suicidal, which societies refused hierarchy, what material forces drove the whole thing, and whether the analysis is even right — only make sense when you can see the pattern across the whole sweep.

A word on why these belong together. The earlier parts risk three distortions, and these chapters are the correction. They risk treating "the many" as undifferentiated, when in fact every hierarchy sorted people by sex, race, age, body, and belonging — so Chapter 1 disaggregates the oppressed. They risk making resistance look like a series of doomed heroic revolts, when most resistance was quiet, daily, and survivable — so Chapter 2 recovers the undramatic counter-current. They risk a subtly Eurocentric, state-centric inevitability, when stateless and non-Western societies are the best evidence against it — so Chapter 3 puts them at the center. They risk treating power as purely social, when bronze, the horse, the plow, and the microchip shaped everything — so Chapter 4 adds the material driver. And they risk special pleading for a thesis — so Chapter 5 makes the strongest possible case *against* the whole project.

Chapter 1 — The sorted: who was pushed below, and through which structures

The first three parts spoke of "Producers" and "Dependents" as if the people in those slots were interchangeable. They never were. Every hierarchy also *sorted* people by who they were — sex, race, age, body, sexuality, belief — and assigned the worst positions accordingly. And crucially, this sorting did not happen only through the *state*. It ran through a whole stack of nested institutions, each with its own power structure: the **household**, the **religious institution**, the **school**, the **state**, the **profession/guild**, the **corporation**, and the diffuse **social** sphere of custom, reputation, and everyday interaction. A person could be a free citizen in the eyes of the state and a subordinate in every other structure at once.

This chapter takes each axis of exclusion and asks how it operated *through that stack* across the eras. The recurring finding: when one structure's grip on a group loosened, another often tightened, so that formal liberation in one domain (say, the legal right to vote) frequently coexisted with continued subordination in the household, the workplace, and the social sphere. Emancipation is not one event but a structure-by-structure campaign, and it is never finished simultaneously.

Gender: the oldest archy, nested in every structure

Patriarchy is the oldest hierarchy and the most thoroughly *distributed* across the institutional stack, which is why it has been the hardest to dislodge — there is no single fortress to storm.

The household is patriarchy's home structure and its engine. The historian Gerda Lerner argued in *The Creation of Patriarchy* that male control over women's reproductive and

productive labor was not a byproduct of inequality but one of its *sources* — that the very practice of treating people as property may have been rehearsed first on women and captives within the household before it was generalized into class and slavery. In the forager era (E1) the gendered division of labor existed but, in mobile bands, conferred relatively little *power* difference, because women's gathering often supplied the dietary staple and nothing could be hoarded. With the Neolithic and the first states (E2–E3), the household became the unit of property and inheritance, and controlling that inheritance meant controlling women's reproduction — hence the policing of female sexuality, the emergence of the bride-price and dowry, and the legal subordination of wife to husband that runs through almost every subsequent legal code (the Roman *paterfamilias* held legal power of life and death; coverture in English common law made the married woman's legal person disappear into her husband's until the 19th century).

The religious institution supplied the Legitiminator function for gender hierarchy across most eras and traditions — doctrines of female subordination, exclusion from the priesthood and from religious learning, and the framing of the gendered household as divinely ordained. (The same institutions also, at times, offered women rare avenues of authority and refuge — the abbess, the female mystic, the religious order that let women escape marriage — a reminder that these structures were never monolithic.)

The school was for most of history simply *closed* to women, which mattered enormously, because exclusion from literacy and credentials locked women out of every role that required them. The opening of female education (a late-19th and 20th-century achievement in most of the world, still contested in places today) was a precondition for everything else, which is why it is so often the first target of both reformers and reactionaries.

The state subordinated women through the denial of the vote (until the 20th-century suffrage movements), of property rights, of the right to hold office, to sit on juries, to control their own bodies and finances. **The profession** and **the corporation** excluded women from guilds, then from most paid professions, then — after admitting them — subordinated them through unequal pay, the "marriage bar" that fired women on marriage, the glass ceiling, and the unpaid "second shift" of domestic labor that the household structure still assigned them. And the **social sphere** enforced all of this through honor codes, reputation, harassment, and the dense web of everyday custom that punished women who stepped outside assigned roles.

The pattern across the eras is *uneven liberation*: women won formal state rights (the vote, legal personhood, property) across the 19th–20th centuries while remaining subordinated in the household, the workplace, and the social sphere — which is precisely why the women's movement had to fight on so many fronts and why "the personal is political" became its defining insight. You cannot legislate the household free.

Race: the hierarchy that was manufactured, then naturalized

Race is the youngest of the great axes and the one whose *manufacture* we can almost date. As Part I argued, premodern slavery and ethnic prejudice existed everywhere, but the idea that humanity divides into biologically ranked *races* was substantially built in Era 6 to justify Atlantic chattel slavery — an ideology produced to resolve the contradiction between Enlightenment universalism and the brute fact of holding humans as property.

Through the structural stack: the **state** codified race through slave codes, then segregation laws, citizenship and immigration restrictions by origin, and apartheid — the legal architecture of racial subordination. The **religious institution** played both sides starkly: supplying biblical justifications for slavery and segregation, and also incubating abolition and civil rights (the Black church as the organizational heart of the American civil rights movement). The **school** segregated and unequally funded, and credentialing systems reproduced racial advantage across generations. The **corporation** and **profession** excluded by race in hiring, lending, and housing — redlining, the color bar, occupational segregation — converting past legal subordination into durable economic inequality even after the laws changed. And the **social sphere** enforced racial hierarchy through everyday violence, exclusion, and the daily indignities that did not require any law at all.

The cross-era lesson mirrors gender's: the *legal* abolition of racial hierarchy (abolition of slavery in E6–E7, the dismantling of legal segregation and apartheid in E7–E8) ran far ahead of its abolition in the corporate, professional, and social structures, where it persists as inherited wealth gaps, occupational sorting, and informal exclusion. Striking down the law is necessary and nowhere near sufficient, because the hierarchy had been built into every other structure too.

Age: the one hierarchy everyone passes through

Age is the strangest axis because, uniquely, *everyone occupies every position in turn* — we are all once young, and most of us become old. This makes it the least "us versus them" of the hierarchies and yet a real structure of power nonetheless.

The young were, across most eras, the property or near-property of the household — child labor was the norm, not the exception, until the industrial-era reform movements (E7) made childhood a protected category and compulsory schooling redefined the child as a student rather than a worker. The **school** is the structure most specific to age: an institution built explicitly around the subordination of the young to adult authority, which can be both developmental and disciplinary. Children remain, in every era including our own, among the least politically enfranchised people — unable to vote, dependent on adults' decisions, their interests represented only indirectly.

The old occupied radically different positions depending on the era's structure. In many forager and traditional societies (E1, and traditional pockets throughout), elders held *high* status precisely because, in a non-literate world, the old were the library — the repository of survival

knowledge, genealogy, and precedent. The written word (E3 onward) and then the printing press and the database progressively *displaced* this function: when knowledge can be stored outside human memory, the elder's monopoly on it erodes. Industrial and present-era economies (E7–E8), organized around wage labor and rapid skill turnover, often pushed the old *out* — mandatory retirement, the devaluing of "obsolete" skills, the warehousing of the elderly away from the productive household. The modern welfare state's pensions (an E7 counter-current achievement) were in part a response to the way industrial capitalism had stripped the old of their former household role and income. Age status, in short, tracks the technology of knowledge and the structure of work: where memory and continuity are valuable, the old rise; where novelty and physical output dominate, they fall.

Disability: the axis defined by the structure itself

Disability reveals something the other axes obscure: that exclusion is often *produced by the structure*, not by the body. A given impairment is disabling only relative to how a society organizes work, space, and worth — this is the core insight of the "social model" of disability. The same body that is excluded by a staircase is included by a ramp; the disability is in the built environment, not only the person.

Across the eras: in subsistence societies (E1–E2), survival of people with significant impairments depended heavily on the group's surplus and ethos, and the archaeological record shows both care (skeletons of individuals who survived for years with conditions requiring others' support — evidence of deep compassion) and, under scarcity, abandonment. The **religious institution** framed disability variously as divine punishment, divine test, or object of charity — the latter producing the almshouse and the hospital, structures of care that were also structures of control and segregation. The **state** moved from this charity model toward, at its worst, active persecution: the same legibility-drive that let the modern state see and serve its population (E7) also enabled it to classify, institutionalize, sterilize, and — in the Nazi case — murder disabled people, the eugenics movement being one of the darkest products of the scientific Legitimater function. The **corporation** and **profession** excluded through inaccessible workplaces and the simple assumption that the "normal" worker was non-disabled, converting impairment into unemployment. The major counter-current is recent: the disability rights movement of the late 20th century (E8), which reframed the issue from individual medical deficit to societal exclusion and won, in many countries, legal mandates for accessibility and against discrimination — a genuinely new kind of emancipation claim, asserting that the *structure* must change to fit the person, not the reverse.

Sexuality and gender nonconformity: the axis of visibility

LGBTQ people present a distinct pattern: an axis where the *degree of recognition itself* — whether the category was even named, criminalized, pathologized, or accepted — swung dramatically across eras and cultures, sometimes more than the underlying acceptance.

The historical record is genuinely varied and resists a simple progress narrative. Some societies across the eras incorporated same-sex relationships, third-gender and gender-variant roles into their accepted structures (recognized gender-variant roles existed in numerous Indigenous societies; same-sex relationships were woven into the social fabric of classical Greece within specific norms; various cultures recognized third-gender categories) — while others criminalized and persecuted them severely. The dominant structure shaping this axis shifted over time. The **religious institution** was the principal definer and persecutor across many eras, framing same-sex behavior and gender nonconformity as sin. The **state** then took up the function through criminal law — sodomy laws, persecution, and in the worst cases mass murder. The **profession** of medicine added, in the industrial and early modern eras (E7), a *pathologizing* layer, reclassifying what had been "sin" as "mental illness," which was a mixed development — it sometimes reduced criminal penalty while imposing a new structure of medical control (forced "treatment," institutionalization).

The counter-current here is among the most recent and rapid in this entire analysis: the LGBTQ rights movements of the late 20th and early 21st centuries (E8) achieved, in many societies, decriminalization, depathologization (the removal of homosexuality from psychiatric disorder classifications), anti-discrimination protections, and recognition of same-sex marriage — a transformation of legal and social status faster than almost any other group's, though deeply uneven across the world and subject to backlash. This axis is the clearest live demonstration of the whole series' thesis that hierarchies are *constructed and contingent*: a category's position can shift dramatically within a single generation, which means no hierarchy's current arrangement is fixed.

The intersection, and the structural lesson

These axes are not independent; they *compound*. A person sits at the intersection of all of them at once, and the structures stack: an enslaved woman in Era 6 was subordinated by race, sex, and legal status simultaneously and through every institution at once — household, plantation (a fusion of corporation and prison), church, and state. The legal scholar Kimberlé Crenshaw named this **intersectionality**: the recognition that someone at the crossing of multiple subordinated categories experiences not the sum but a distinct *compounding* of disadvantage that single-axis remedies miss.

The structural lesson of the whole chapter is this: **emancipation is not one battle but a campaign across the entire institutional stack, and it is never won everywhere at once**. A group can be liberated by the state while still subordinated in the household, the corporation, and the social sphere — and the unfinished structures are where the hierarchy retreats to and regroups. This is sobering, but it is also the source of hope in the next chapter: because the structures are many and distinct, they can be contested one at a time, and progress in one is real even when the others lag.

Chapter 2 — Resistance without revolt: the quiet counter-current

The earlier parts tracked the dramatic counter-currents — the jubilee, Spartacus, the peasant risings, abolition, Haiti, the unions. But open revolt is rare, dangerous, and usually crushed. For most people in most eras, resisting the powerful by rising up was simply suicidal. So they resisted in other ways — quieter, slower, survivable, and cumulatively powerful. This chapter recovers that hidden counter-current, because it is where most of the actual pushing-back happened, and because it speaks directly to the question of how abusive structures get dismantled when you *cannot* storm them.

The anthropologist James C. Scott called these the **"weapons of the weak"**: the everyday forms of resistance available to people with no army, no vote, and no voice. Foot-dragging, working slowly, feigned ignorance, false compliance, pilfering, sabotage, desertion, gossip, satire, the strategic misunderstanding of orders. Scott's insight was that these are not failures to resist — they *are* resistance, the form it takes when open defiance means death, and in aggregate they impose real limits on what the powerful can extract. A field full of peasants who all work just a little slower than they could, who let a little grain "spill," who develop a convenient deafness when given an unreasonable order, are collectively bargaining without ever holding a meeting.

The forms, across the eras

Flight and exit. The oldest weapon, inherited from the forager's right to walk away (E1). When the structures permit it, leaving is the purest resistance — it withdraws the one thing the powerful cannot do without, your labor and your body. Enslaved people in the Atlantic system (E6) ran, and the **maroon communities** they founded in the mountains and swamps of the Americas — Palmares in Brazil sheltered thousands for most of a century — were entire societies built by people who resisted by *leaving and staying gone*. Serfs fled to the towns, where (by the medieval principle that "town air makes free") a year and a day of residence could dissolve their bondage. The peasant who slips across the border, the worker who quits, the dissident who emigrates — all are using the forager's first weapon. Exit's power is exactly why every archy works to abolish it (Part I's "loss of exit" thread): binding labor to land, the pass laws, the company town, the debt that cannot be outrun. Where exit survives, the powerful are checked; where it is closed, the quiet weapons turn inward.

Sabotage and the slowdown. Damaging the tools, the work, or the pace. The word "sabotage" itself may descend from the wooden shoe (*sabot*) and the slow, clumsy work of the resentful laborer. The slave who "accidentally" broke the plow, the factory worker who threw a shoe into the machine, the modern employee performing the bare minimum — all impose a tax on extraction. The slowdown and the "work-to-rule" (following every rule so literally that production grinds to a halt) are revolt's survivable cousins: they cannot be punished as mutiny because nothing was openly refused.

Hidden transcripts: satire, gossip, and the safe space. Scott also documented the "**hidden transcript**" — the critique of power that the subordinate share among themselves, out of the master's hearing, even while performing deference to his face. The slave spirituals with double meanings, the peasant folktales in which the clever weak outwit the strong, the political joke whispered under tyranny, the satire that says what cannot be said. These kept alive the *knowledge that the hierarchy was not just or natural* — they preserved the leveling consciousness of E1 underground, through eras when expressing it openly was fatal, so that it was ready when conditions finally allowed open action. The hidden transcript is the seedbank of the counter-current.

Building the alternative alongside. Often the most durable resistance is not attacking the structure but *building a parallel one*. The mutual-aid society, the cooperative, the credit union, the underground school, the dissident church, the free clinic, the commons held in common against enclosure. These create, inside the shell of the hierarchical society, pockets that run on different principles — and they double as the organizational base from which open movements later grow (the Black church and the civil rights movement; the union hall; the safe houses of every underground railroad). This is resistance as *construction*, and it is perhaps the most hopeful form, because it does not wait for the structure to fall before beginning to live differently.

Using the master's tools: law, literacy, and the appeal upward. Subordinate groups have repeatedly turned the powerful's own instruments against them — petitioning, litigating, invoking the regime's stated ideals to shame it into honoring them. Enslaved and colonized people sued for freedom in the colonizer's courts; workers used the law to enforce the rights the law nominally granted; movements held nations to the promises in their own founding documents ("we hold these truths to be self-evident"). This is the jubilee logic (E3) inverted — instead of relief granted from above, it is relief *demand*ed by invoking the ruler's own legitimating story against him. It works precisely because the Legitimator function (Part III) requires the powerful to *claim* justice; once that claim is made, it can be turned into a lever.

Why the quiet counter-current matters

Three reasons this chapter is, despite its undramatic subject, the most hopeful in this work.

First, **it is always available**. Revolt requires conditions — concentration, opportunity, a crack in the regime — that are rare. The quiet weapons require none of them. They are the resistance of the powerless *as such*, available in the darkest eras and the tightest structures, which means the counter-current never fully goes dormant.

Second, **it is cumulatively decisive**. Historians increasingly credit the day-to-day resistance of the enslaved — the flights, the slowdowns, the sabotage, the maintenance of family and culture against all pressure — as central to making slavery unprofitable and ungovernable, not merely the dramatic revolts. The Black Death gave peasants leverage, but it was their willingness to

use it — to leave, to demand, to refuse the old dues — that actually dissolved western serfdom (E5). Quiet resistance sets the terms that open movements later formalize.

Third, **it preserves the alternative**. The hidden transcript and the parallel institutions keep alive, through the worst eras, the knowledge and the practice of living differently. When Part I asked whether archy was inevitable, the deepest answer is in this chapter: the leveling consciousness of the foragers was never extinguished, because the powerless carried it underground in their jokes, their songs, their mutual aid, and their refusals — ready to surface whenever a crack appeared. The hope of dismantling abusive structures does not rest only on the rare revolution. It rests on the fact that human beings, in every era and every structure, have never fully consented to their own domination, and have always found ways — quiet, daily, survivable — to withhold that consent and to build, in the cracks, the beginnings of something else.

Chapter 3 — The counter-cases: societies that refused kings

The inevitability thesis lives or dies on the exceptions. If every complex society became a hierarchy, then archy is destiny and the rest is decoration. But complex societies that stayed flat, or that built genuine scale without permanent rulers, are scattered across the whole record — and the first three parts kept them at the margins. This chapter brings them to the center, because they are the strongest evidence in the entire work that hierarchy is a *choice* repeatedly made and repeatedly refused, not a law of social physics.

The cases below are deliberately drawn from across continents and eras, to break the assumption that the European-to-global trajectory was the only one available.

Stateless complexity in the deep past

We met these in Part I; here they anchor the argument. **Çatalhöyük** (E2) housed thousands of fully agricultural people for roughly a millennium in near-identical houses with no palace and no elite quarter — surplus and density without rank. The **Indus Valley civilization** (E3) ran some of the largest, most sophisticated planned cities of the ancient world for centuries with no convincing evidence of kings, royal tombs, or god-king iconography. The Ukrainian "**mega-sites**" (Trypillia culture, E2) gathered thousands of people into large planned settlements arranged in egalitarian concentric circles with no central palace or citadel — apparently governed without a dominating center. And the **Carpathian Basin** communities, recent research found, resisted the emergence of inequality for some five thousand years. None of these was a small band that simply hadn't grown up yet; they were large, complex, durable societies that had every supposed precondition for kingship and *did not produce it*.

Indigenous federations and councils

The Americas before and during European contact contained a range of political forms, including sophisticated *confederations* that distributed power deliberately. The **Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Confederacy** united several nations under the Great Law of Peace, governed by a council of chiefs chosen by — and removable by — clan mothers, operating by consensus across the member nations. Power was checked, accountable, gendered in a way that gave women real political authority (the right to select and depose leaders), and explicitly designed to prevent domination. Graeber and Wengrow argue that Indigenous critiques of European hierarchy — articulated by figures like the Wendat statesman Kandiaronk in recorded debates with Europeans — were sophisticated political philosophy that may have fed back into the European Enlightenment's own ideas of liberty and equality. The point is not to romanticize (these societies had their own conflicts, captures, and slaveries) but to register that *accountable, consensus-based, deliberately power-limiting governance at scale* was a developed and theorized Indigenous achievement, not a European invention.

African political diversity beyond the state

Precolonial Africa contained the full range of political forms — centralized kingdoms and empires (Mali, Great Zimbabwe, the Asante) but also a vast number of **stateless or "acephalous" (headless) societies** that organized substantial populations without centralized rulers, through age-set systems, councils of elders, kinship networks, secret societies that checked power, and what anthropologists call **heterarchy** — systems in which different functions are governed by different overlapping bodies, so that no single hierarchy dominates all domains. The Igbo, the Tiv, the Nuer and many others ran complex social orders with mechanisms specifically designed to *prevent* the concentration of permanent authority. The colonial powers, encountering these, frequently could not even *recognize* them as governance — and so imposed chiefs ("warrant chiefs") where none had existed, manufacturing a hierarchy to have someone to rule through. The lesson is double: stateless complex order was widespread, *and* one of colonialism's functions was to destroy it and install archy where flatter forms had prevailed.

The radically democratic margins

Even within the heart of hierarchical eras, pockets of deliberate equality appeared. **Pirate ships** of the early 18th century (E6) — crewed largely by men who had fled the brutal hierarchy of the merchant and naval marine — frequently operated under written **articles** that the crew signed: the captain was *elected* and could be deposed, plunder was shared on a fixed and relatively flat scale, the quartermaster checked the captain's power, and disabled crew received compensation from a common fund. A floating society of the violently excluded built, by deliberate agreement, one of the flatter and more democratic orders of its age — a vivid case of people who had experienced the hierarchy at its worst designing an alternative. Comparable experiments recur: the medieval free cities and communes, the radical-democratic moments of

revolutions (the sections of revolutionary Paris, the councils and soviets before they were captured, the anarchist collectives of 1930s Spain), the intentional communities. Most were crushed or curdled, but their recurrence across every era is itself the evidence — the impulse to build flat, accountable order is perennial, not exotic.

What the counter-cases establish

Three conclusions, escalating in force.

First, **complex society does not require kings**. The flat cities of the deep past and the headless societies of Africa prove that scale, agriculture, trade, and durability are all compatible with the absence of permanent centralized rule. The supposed iron chain from surplus to the state has too many missing links.

Second, **accountable power is an achievement, not a default — and it has been achieved many times, in many places, independently**. The Haudenosaunee council, the African age-sets, the pirate articles, the revolutionary commune — these are not one tradition diffusing outward but *repeated independent inventions* of mechanisms to check domination. That recurrence is exactly what you would expect if the leveling impulse of Part I is a permanent feature of human beings, surfacing wherever it gets the chance.

Third, **archy often had to be actively imposed and the alternatives actively destroyed**. The warrant chiefs of colonial Africa, the crushing of the communes, the suppression of the maroons — repeatedly, hierarchy did not simply *emerge* from complexity; it was *installed*, often violently, over flatter forms that were working. This inverts the inevitability story entirely: in many times and places, the historical labor went not into building equality against a natural tendency to hierarchy, but into building hierarchy against a stubborn human capacity for equality.

Chapter 4 — The material drivers: technology and ecology

The first three parts told the story largely in social terms — mechanisms, roles, institutions. But underneath the social story runs a material one: specific *technologies* and *ecological conditions* that opened or closed the doors to power, often decisively. This chapter traces those material drivers, because they explain *why* the mechanisms switched on when and where they did, and because they puncture any purely idealist account in which hierarchy is just a matter of ideas and choices. Ideas and choices operate within material constraints, and sometimes the material constraint is the whole story.

A caution before the catalogue: the relationship between technology and hierarchy is not deterministic. The same tool empowers domination in one social setting and resistance in another — the printing press served both the censor and the heretic. Technology *shifts the*

odds; it does not dictate the outcome. With that caveat, the material drivers fall into a few families.

The storable-surplus complex: domestication and the plow

The foundational material driver, already central to Part I: the domestication of storable cereal crops and herd animals (E2) created, for the first time, wealth that could be hoarded, counted, taxed, and inherited. But the single most striking *quantified* material driver in this entire work is the **draft animal and the plow**. The Kohler study found that the biggest divergence between Old World and New World inequality came down to this: Eurasia had large domesticable animals — oxen, horses, water buffalo — and the Americas did not. Draft animals let a wealthy household work far more land than its own muscles could, pulling the plow that broke heavy soils, which let the rich expand their holdings and created a class of landless laborers beneath them. Inequality, the study argues, rose on *both ends* — the animal-owning rich got richer and the landless poor got poorer — and this is much of why Old World Ginis climbed toward ~0.59 while New World inequality plateaued lower. A single ecological accident — which continents happened to have rideable, yokeable mammals — shaped the divergent inequality trajectories of entire hemispheres.

This is the material root of the "control of subsistence" mechanism (Part I). Grain is the perfect substance for archy: it ripens predictably (so it can be taxed on a schedule), it stores (so it can be hoarded and controlled), and it is visible and divisible (so it can be assessed and seized). The anthropologist James Scott argued that early states formed specifically around *cereal* agriculture for exactly these reasons — that you cannot build a tax-collecting state on cassava or potatoes that hide underground and can be dug as needed, but you can build one on wheat standing assessable in a field. The crop's biology shaped the politics.

The metals and the mounted warrior

Bronze and then iron metallurgy (late E2 into E3–E4) did two opposed things. Iron, once cheap, democratized tools and weapons — an iron blade in many hands. But the warrior complex it enabled — bronze weapons, then the horse, the chariot, and eventually the mounted, armored cavalryman — created a military aristocracy. The Kohler researchers specifically credit the arrival of bronze metallurgy and a *mounted warrior elite* with driving Old World inequality up through large houses and territorial conquest. The horse in particular is a recurring engine of domination: it gave its possessors a decisive military and mobility advantage, underwrote the steppe empires and the conquering cavalries, and made the Enforcer role (Part III) physically dominant. The feudal knight (E5) is, materially, a man who can afford a warhorse and armor — the whole three-orders hierarchy rests partly on the expense of mounted warfare.

The technologies of legibility: writing, printing, the database

Document three's "ledger" mechanism has a precise material history. **Writing** (E3), born as accountancy, gave power its memory — the ability to record what is owed and owned beyond

the limits of any human mind. **The printing press** (15th century, late E5 into E6) is the great double-edged case: it served the state and church (mass-produced propaganda, standardized scripture, bureaucratic forms) *and* shattered their monopoly on the Legitimater function — it powered the Reformation by putting the Bible in vernacular hands, spread the pamphlets of every subsequent revolution, and created the public sphere in which the powerful could be criticized at scale. The same technology centralized and decentralized authority at once. **The census and statistics** (E7) made whole populations legible. And the **database and the networked sensor** (E8) complete the arc, giving power not just memory but prediction — the capacity to know individuals with a granularity that earlier states could only dream of. Each step in this family extended the reach of the ledger; each was also, in turn, seized by the counter-current as a tool of resistance (the dissident's printing press, the activist's network).

The energy revolutions

The deepest material driver of the modern eras is *energy*. Human and animal muscle, then water and wind, then — transformatively — **fossil fuels** (E7). The steam engine and then the internal combustion engine and electrification multiplied the power available to society by orders of magnitude, and this is the material foundation of industrial capitalism: the factory, the railroad, the mechanized everything. Energy abundance enabled the population explosion, the vast new scale of production, and the surplus that funded both the worst exploitation and, eventually, the welfare state. It also concentrated a new kind of power in whoever controlled the energy sources — the coal seam, the oil field — adding a new resource to the list of things over which archy is built. The current contest over energy (and the ecological limits fossil energy has brought us to) is, in this frame, the latest chapter of a story in which who controls the society's power supply shapes who holds power over its people.

Ecology as constraint and shock

Finally, ecology operates not just as resource but as *constraint and shock*. Climate shifts repeatedly destabilized regimes (drought and the collapse of several Bronze Age states; the cold spells that triggered famines and revolts). Disease, as Chapter 5 will press, was one of history's great levelers — the Black Death (E5) killed enough people to invert the land-labor ratio and dissolve western serfdom. Geography shaped what was possible: societies with access to defensible mountains and swamps gave their maroons and rebels somewhere to flee (preserving exit); societies on open plains were easier to conquer and tax. The material world set the board on which the social game of archy was played.

The lesson: material odds, social choices

The material drivers explain the *timing and the odds* — why hierarchy became available when and where it did, why some continents grew more unequal than others, why certain technologies tilted the field toward domination or toward resistance. But they do not, by themselves, dictate the outcome, and the counter-cases of Chapter 3 prove it: Çatalhöyük had the grain and stayed flat; the Indus had the cities and seemingly no kings. The honest synthesis

is that **technology and ecology load the dice, and the social mechanisms and human choices of the first three parts throw them.** Neither the purely material nor the purely social account is complete. Archy is what happens when a particular material configuration meets a particular social one — and changing either can change the result, which is why the present era's combination of new energy constraints and new information technologies makes the current arrangement, like every previous one, genuinely up for grabs.

Part V — The Case Against This Analysis

The honest objections. The preceding four parts built and complicated an argument; this part turns the strongest available objections against the whole of it, and concedes what an honest reader might conclude instead.

A work that argues a position should be able to make the strongest possible case *against* itself. This whole inquiry leans toward a particular reading: that archy is a contingent deviation from a human capacity for equality, that it is built rather than natural, and that it can therefore be unbuilt. That reading is contestable, and an honest account owes the objections their full force — not as straw men to be knocked down, but as serious arguments that a thoughtful reader might find more convincing than the thesis. This part steelmans five of them.

Objection 1: Hierarchy is natural, not a deviation

The series treats forager equality as the human baseline and archy as the deviation. The opposing view, with real evidence behind it, runs the other way: we are primates, and primates build dominance hierarchies. Our closest relatives, chimpanzees, live in steep, often violent status hierarchies; status-seeking, coalition-building, and the drive to rise are deeply rooted in primate (and human) psychology. On this reading, forager equality is not the natural human state but a hard-won, fragile *suppression* of our natural tendency to dominate — which is exactly why foragers needed all those active leveling mechanisms (the ridicule, the demand-sharing, the threat of ostracism). You don't need elaborate machinery to enforce a tendency that comes naturally; you need it to suppress one that doesn't. The very existence of the leveling toolkit, the objection says, proves that the dominance drive was always there, straining against the leash. And the moment conditions allowed — surplus, sedentism — hierarchy reasserted itself everywhere, because it was the default all along.

The series' best reply is that the *capacity* for both is real, and that the leveling machinery proves humans can and did choose equality for the vast majority of our history — but the objection has force, and it should unsettle anyone too confident that equality is our "true" nature waiting to be liberated.

Objection 2: Hierarchy is efficient, and it funded everything good

This work frames archy almost entirely as extraction and domination. But there is a powerful functionalist case that hierarchy *earns its keep*. Coordination at scale requires someone to coordinate; large projects (the irrigation systems, the granaries that buffered famine, the roads, the defense against raiders) require concentrated authority to organize them. The surplus that elites extracted also *funded* the specialists — the metallurgists, the astronomers, the scribes, the artists, the philosophers — whose work created the science, technology, literature, and art we treasure. Division of labor, which requires that some people not farm, is the engine of all cultural and material progress, and it is inseparable from some people directing others. On this view, the forager equality this work admires came bundled with permanent poverty, no writing, no medicine, no accumulated knowledge — a flat society precisely because it was a society with almost nothing to be unequal *about*. The god-king was monstrous, but the granary he controlled also kept his people alive through the lean years, and the civilization he taxed into being is the one that eventually produced the very ideas of rights and equality this work champions. You may not be able to have the Enlightenment without first having the pharaohs.

The series can reply that the counter-cases (Chapter 3) show much of this coordination was achievable *without* permanent rulers, and that the "hierarchy funded progress" story conveniently credits the elite for the work of the many. But the functionalist case is not absurd, and the burden is on the egalitarian to show that complex coordination and accumulated knowledge can be sustained at scale without *some* concentration of authority — a thing more often asserted than demonstrated.

Objection 3: Inequality is the price of innovation and freedom

A narrower modern version of the efficiency argument: that *some* inequality is not just tolerable but necessary and even just. If people are free to work, create, invent, and trade, they will produce unequal results, because human talents and efforts are unequal — and the alternative, enforced equality of outcome, requires exactly the kind of coercive central power this work otherwise deplors. The 20th century's attempts to abolish inequality by force (the communist revolutions) produced not equality but new and often murderous hierarchies of party and state, and immense human suffering. The incentive to rise — to get rich by building something people want — drives the innovation that has, on this account, lifted billions out of the absolute poverty that was the *real* condition of the egalitarian past. Inequality of reward is the engine; flattening it stalls the engine. A society that lets no one rise far above the rest may be equal, but it may also be stagnant and poor, and its equality may require a boot on every neck to maintain.

This objection cuts deep because it turns this work's own values against it: the coercion it fears is precisely what enforced equality has historically required. The reply is that there is a vast space between "some inequality from genuine free contribution" and the present concentration where a few thousand people hold more than half of humanity — that the question is not equality-versus-inequality but *how much, from what, and with what mobility*. But the objection

rightly warns that "abolish inequality" is a dangerous slogan if it is not disciplined by the question of what replaces it.

Objection 4: The egalitarian past is romanticized

This work leans on forager equality and the stateless counter-cases as proof that things can be otherwise. The objection: this romanticizes societies that were, by most measures we care about, grim. Forager and stateless life often meant short lifespans, high child mortality, chronic vulnerability to famine and weather, and — contrary to the "peaceful savage" image — rates of violent death from raiding and feud that, as a *proportion* of the population, often exceeded those of the modern states this work criticizes. The "equality" was partly the equality of shared poverty and shared danger. The leveling mechanisms this work admires included, at the extreme, *killing* people who got too big — egalitarianism enforced by homicide. The Indigenous and stateless societies held up as alternatives had their own slaveries, their own patriarchies, their own captures and cruelties. Selecting the flat and accountable cases (the Haudenosaunee council, the pirate articles) while passing quickly over the violent and hierarchical ones (and many stateless societies were neither peaceful nor equal) is cherry-picking in service of a thesis.

The series' honest reply is that it has tried to flag these (the forager execution of upstarts, the "don't romanticize" cautions in Chapter 3) — but the objection is correct that the *selection* of cases tilts hopeful, and that a fully honest account must weigh the brutal stateless societies as heavily as the admirable ones.

Objection 5: Inequality never falls without catastrophe — so hope is misplaced

This is the gravest objection, and it comes from the historian Walter Scheidel, whose *The Great Leveler* surveys the same sweep of history this work does and reaches a far bleaker conclusion. Scheidel argues that since humans began to farm, herd, and pass on assets, inequality has been a defining feature of civilization, and over thousands of years only violent events have significantly lessened it. He identifies "Four Horsemen" of leveling — mass-mobilization warfare, transformative revolution, state collapse, and catastrophic plague — that have repeatedly destroyed the fortunes of the rich, and argues that every major reduction in economic inequality has been linked to some massive, violent shock that upended the established order. The peaceful reforms this work celebrates — the unions, the franchise, the welfare state — were not, on Scheidel's account, autonomous victories of the counter-current at all: the mid-20th-century compression was largely a product of the social solidarity and upheaval created by the two World Wars, and once that shock faded, after 1945 tax rates on the wealthiest started falling and inequality resumed its climb. The leveling of the Black Death (E5), too, worked by killing enough people to change the ratio of land to labor, raising wages — and was slowly reversed as populations rebounded.

If Scheidel is right, the entire hopeful arc of this series is an illusion. The quiet resistance of Chapter 2, the counter-cases of Chapter 3, the democratic capture of the mid-century — none of it represents a peaceful path to equality, because there *is* no peaceful path. Equality has only ever been bought with mass death, and it has never lasted. And the modern good news — that the Four Horsemen have "dismounted their steeds," as mass-mobilization war, transformative revolution, state collapse, and civilization-ending plague all look unlikely — is, on Scheidel's reading, also the bad news: the very stability that spares us catastrophe also removes the only force that has ever flattened the pyramid. We may be stuck with rising inequality precisely *because* we are, mercifully, no longer subject to the horrors that once reduced it.

The series owes this its most serious engagement, because it is built on the same evidence and is not easily dismissed. Three replies are available, and none is a knockout. First, *measurement*: Scheidel's focus on material wealth inequality may understate the genuine, durable, and largely peaceful gains in *legal and social* hierarchy — the abolition of slavery, of coverture, of legal caste, of segregation, the enfranchisement of women, the decriminalization of being gay — which are real reductions in *archy* (the power of one over another) even where wealth Ginis kept climbing. The series defined archy more broadly than wealth, and on that broader measure the peaceful counter-current has clear, lasting wins. Second, *causation is contested*: other scholars argue Scheidel underweights the autonomous role of organized politics, ideas, and institutions, and that the violence and the reform were intertwined rather than the violence being the sole cause. Third, *the future is not the past*: the material drivers of Chapter 4 are shifting — new energy systems, new information technologies, new ecological limits — and a future that does not resemble the agrarian past may not be bound by its iron law, for better or worse.

But intellectual honesty requires the concession: **Scheidel may simply be right, and the hopeful reading wrong.** It is entirely possible that the peaceful taming of archy is rare, fragile, and shock-dependent, and that the comfortable stability of the present is also a trap. The series' hope is defensible, but it is not certain, and a reader persuaded by Scheidel has every right to find this whole project's optimism unearned.

Why the objections strengthen rather than destroy the analysis

Holding these five objections together, what survives of this work's thesis? Not the strongest version — not "equality is our true nature and archy is a removable error." What survives is the weaker, more defensible claim the work actually built toward: that **archy is conditional, not inevitable; that humans demonstrably carry both the capacity to dominate and the capacity to level; that which one prevails depends on mechanisms, roles, material conditions, and choices that have been arranged many different ways; and that the arrangement is therefore, in principle, contestable — though contesting it peacefully and durably is far harder than the hopeful reading suggests, and may be rarer than we would like to believe.**

That is a more modest thesis than this work sometimes reaches for, and the objections are what discipline it down to honesty. The strongest case against the analysis does not destroy it; it strips away its overconfidence and leaves the defensible core — which is, in the end, the most that history honestly supports: not that we are destined for equality, nor that we are doomed to hierarchy, but that we have always been, and remain, the animal that builds both and must keep choosing between them.

Conclusion to the combined volume

The five parts approach one history from five angles, and it is worth drawing them back together.

Part I traced the *mechanisms* — the door-opening devices by which power over others is generated, and the leveling devices that resist them — and established that sustained equality, not hierarchy, was the human baseline. Part II made that quantitative, measuring group sizes, what people kept versus surrendered, and the inequality that followed, era by era. Part III supplied fixed categories — six functional roles and the administrative machine they operate — and showed that archy concentrates when the roles bundle at the apex and the machine is captured from above. Part IV cut across the eras: it disaggregated "the many" into the specific groups every hierarchy sorted to the bottom and showed their subordination ran through the whole institutional stack, so that emancipation has always been a campaign across many fronts, never won everywhere at once; it recovered the quiet counter-current — flight, sabotage, the hidden transcript, the parallel institution — that carried the leveling impulse through eras when open revolt meant death; it put the stateless and non-Western societies that refused kings at the center, finding that complex society never required rulers and that archy often had to be actively imposed over flatter forms that worked; and it added the material drivers — the plow, the horse, the press, the engine, the database, the ecological shocks — that loaded the dice the social mechanisms then threw. And Part V turned the strongest objections against the whole project, conceding that the hopeful reading may be wrong, that hierarchy may be natural and efficient and reducible only by catastrophe, and that what honestly survives is a more modest thesis than the work sometimes reached for.

That modest, disciplined thesis is the real conclusion, and it is worth stating once more in its chastened form. Archy — the power of one human over another — is neither our destiny nor our error to simply correct. It is conditional: a product of mechanisms, roles, material conditions, and choices that have been arranged in radically different ways across the human story, from the flat band to the god-king to the brief mid-century taming to the present re-concentration. The excluded have always resisted, usually quietly; the alternatives have always existed, often crushed; the material world has always shaped the odds; and the question has never been settled. We are the animal that builds both hierarchy and its undoing, and the evidence of the

whole long record is not that one is bound to win, but that the contest is permanent — which means it is open now, as it has always been.